MODULE 07 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

The Kill Decision

Why should this startup die?

COURSE PATH



COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 07-rapid-validation
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M07_Lecture_Rapid-Validation.pdf, download top right

Public course repository of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. The QR code opens github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship.

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

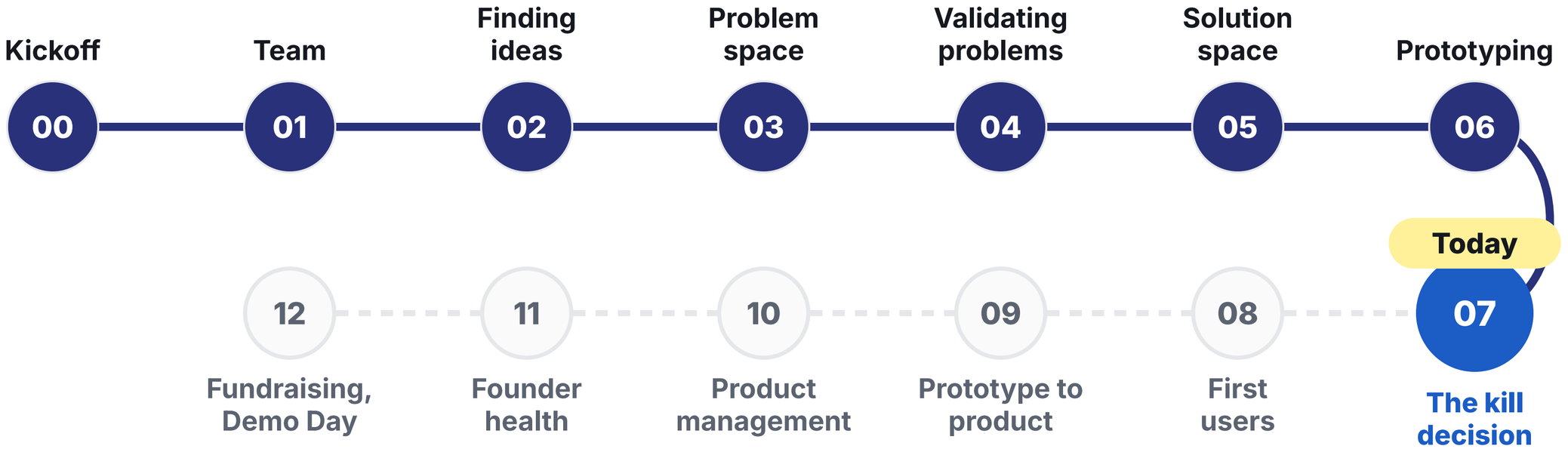
From evidence to a verdict

Thirteen sessions from first idea to first revenue. What teams have by now:

A problem people confirmed
Problem space (M03)

A live MVP and fixes shipped
Prototyping (M06)

Use records against a line
Prototyping (M06)



CHECK-IN · SHOW OF HANDS

Go, Pivot or Kill? Your gut, right now

Hands up for your band. One click on the band per hand



Go

persevere



Pivot

change one thing



Kill

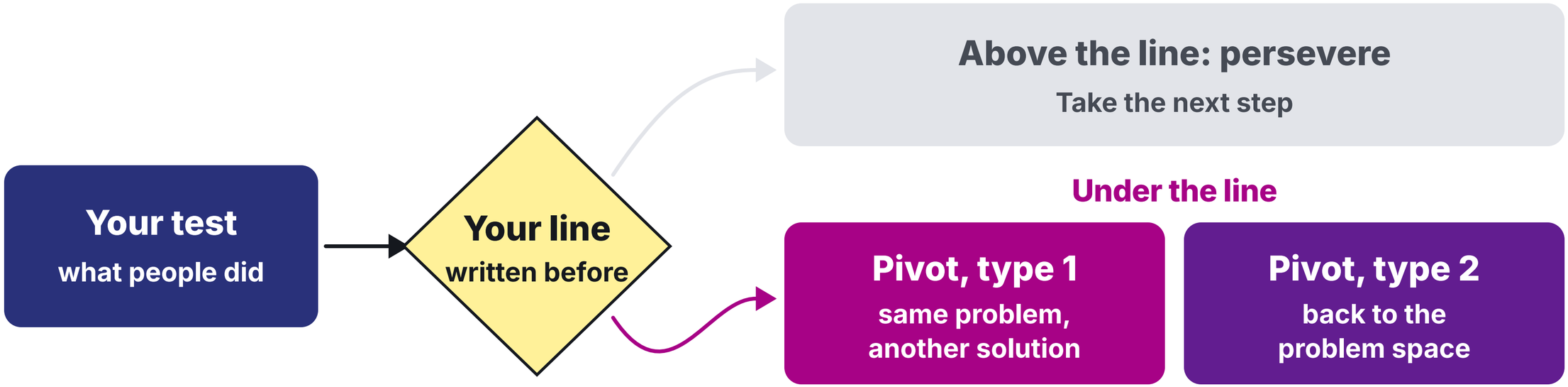
stop this venture



PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

Go means persevere. Pivot has two types. Today adds the third move, kill



Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Report what you did, not what you planned



User interactions?

What did you learn?



New revenue?

Why did they pay?



Shipped?

Why does it matter?

🦄 **Report target vs. actual in small groups**

CHAPTER 1 OF 10

Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

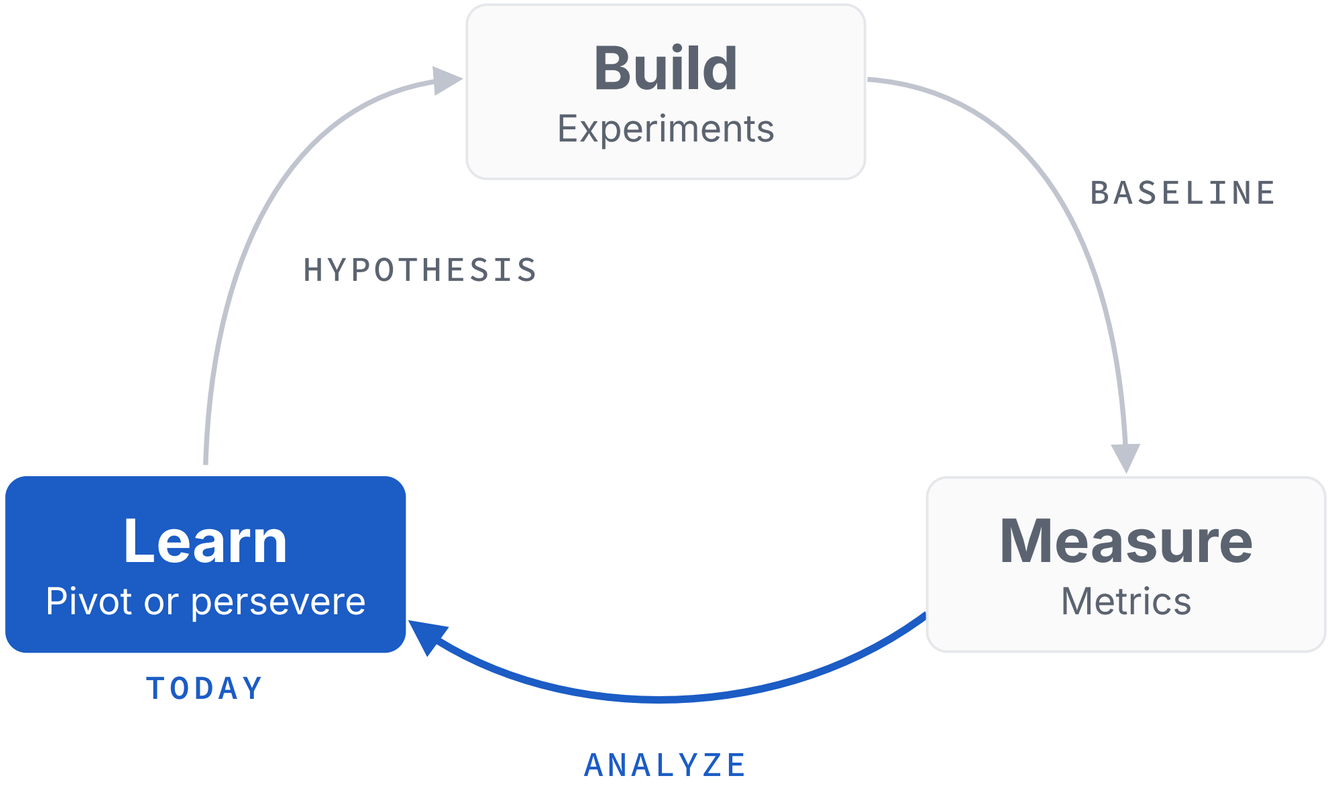
Three pictures from earlier sessions that you need to follow today.

01 **Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship**
02 Your presentations
03 **List it: every way it could die**
04 **Rank it: the monkey first**
05 **Judge it: your past self decides**
06 **Close it: kill well, then restart**
07 Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter
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PREVIOUSLY · KICKOFF (M00)

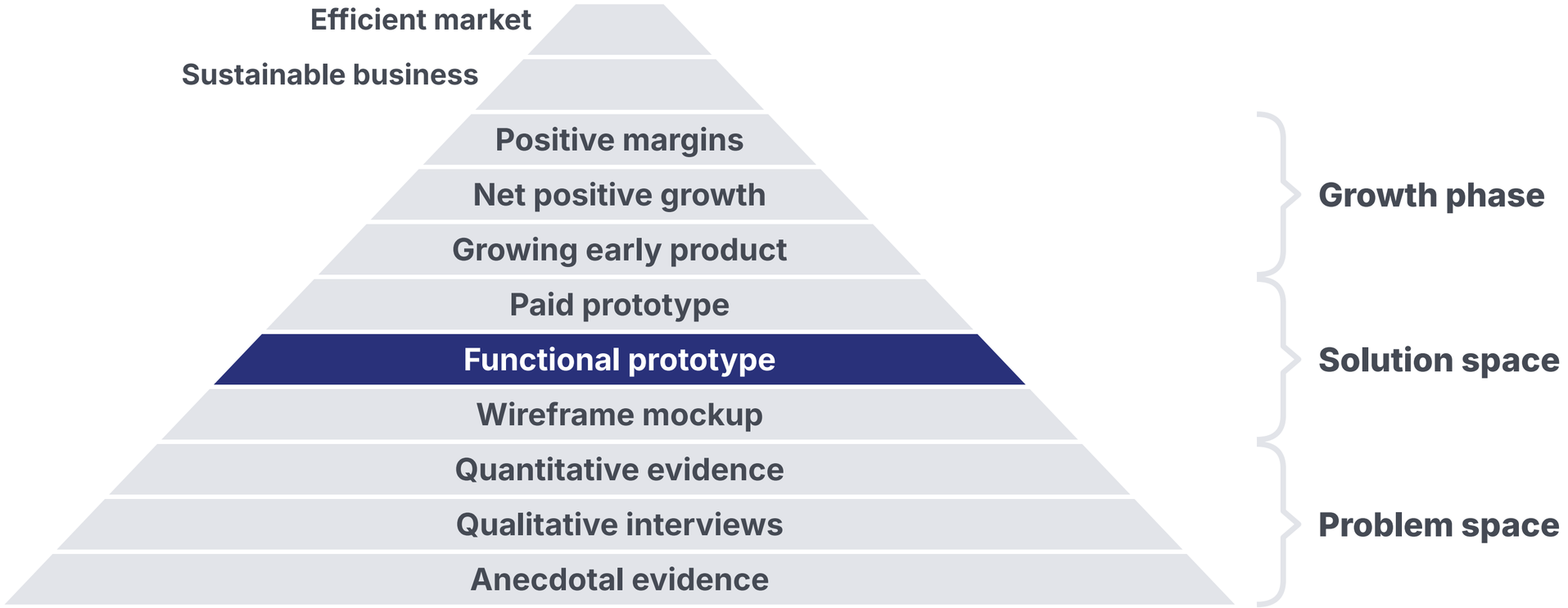
Every loop ends in a decision

Build the smallest test, measure what people do, then pivot or persevere



PREVIOUSLY · PROTOTYPING (M06)

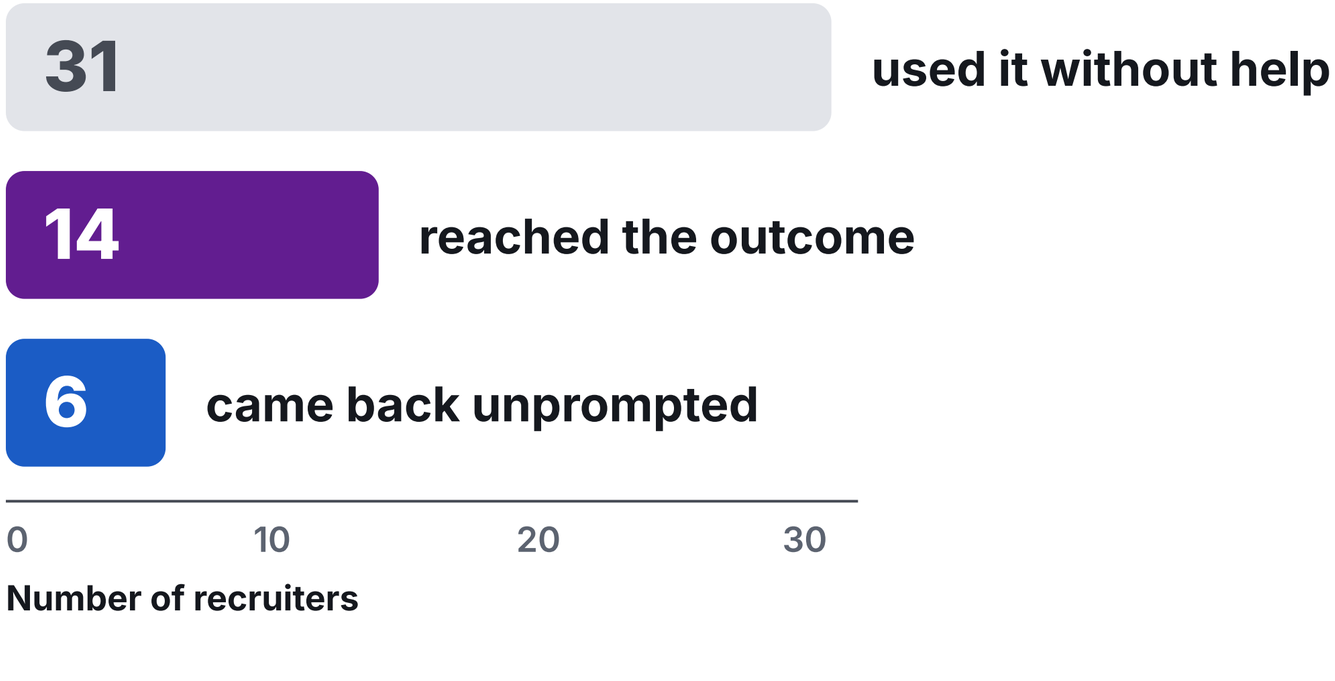
You climbed to a slice that works



PREVIOUSLY · YOUR USE RECORDS · MADE UP

Did they reach the outcome, and come back?

The made-up recruiting venture, counted from its use records





ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture, from the Prototyping (M06) homework. Bars to scale. Photo: Tumisu on Pixabay.

TODAY'S QUESTION · HANDS

Why should this startup die?

1:00

CHAPTER 2 OF 10

Your presentations

Your use records next to your line, three minutes per team.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
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YOUR PRESENTATIONS · MAKE IT CREDIBLE

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

3:00

Facts

Statistics or research

The outcome you promise, what they used before

12 Numbers

Usage or surveys

Users without help, reached the outcome, came back unprompted

Quotes

Interviews

Two from users, with roles

Images

Screenshots or users

The outcome screen, one fix before and after

Verdict: above or below your line, and what it triggered

What did you do? **What did you learn?** **How can we help?**

INPUT 1 OF 4 · CHAPTER 3 OF 10

List it: every way it could die

Imagine your venture dead, and turn every cause into an assumption you can check.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 **List it: every way it could die**
04 **Rank it: the monkey first**
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INPUT 1 OF 4 · LIST IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Why could your venture die?

1



What turns an assumption into a hypothesis?

2



How do you find the assumptions you rely on?

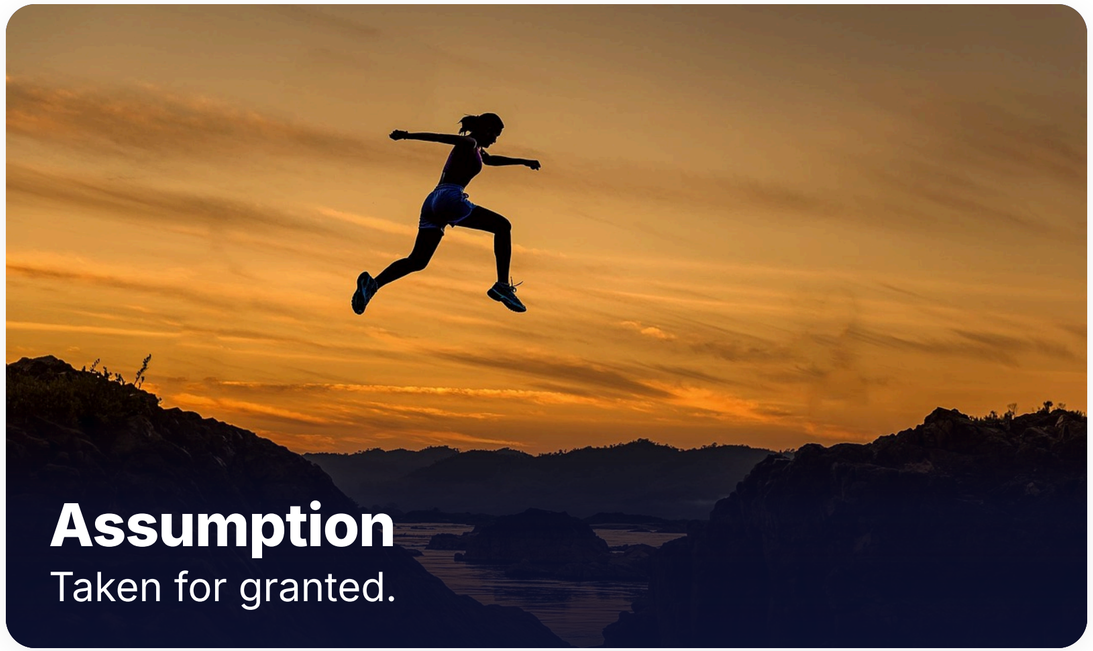
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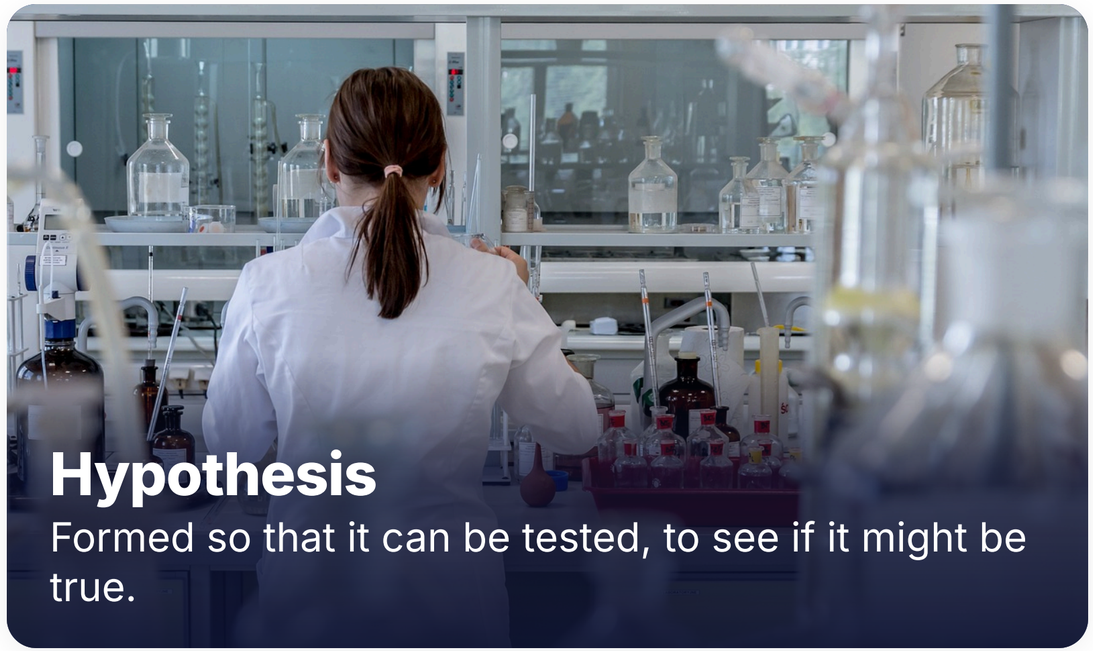
Which of them still matter?

ASSUMPTION VS. HYPOTHESIS

A hypothesis is an assumption that can fail



Assumption
Taken for granted.



Hypothesis
Formed so that it can be tested, to see if it might be true.

Until founders test them in the real world, they are not validated.

WORKED EXAMPLE · BASTIAN'S COURSE IDEA

Every idea hides assumptions. Find three

> Through our contact with startup founders, we have learnt that many work in a very unstructured way. This led to the idea of an online course that teaches founders to set up internal structures on Notion.

Assumption! Do they struggle?
We have never spoken to founders about this.

Assumption! Why online?
I get paid to teach online courses. That does not mean founders want one.

Assumption! Why Notion?
We like Notion. I think everybody should use it.

Logos are trademarks of their owners.

THE PRE-MORTEM

Imagine your venture is dead, one year from now

Then write down why, before the market does



Klein's example

A billion-dollar project "failed" because interest waned when the CEO retired

1

Imagine

One year from now. It is dead.

2

Write alone

Every founder lists causes, silently.

3

Translate

Each cause becomes an assumption.

4

Check

Against seven weeks of records.

FRAMEWORK Gary Klein, "Performing a project premortem", Harvard Business Review, September 2007. Steps 3 and 4 are the course's. Photo: websubs on Pixabay.

KICKOFF (M00) AUTOPSIED AN IDEA · MADE UP

Today you autopsy a venture with evidence

Your Weekly Reflection, "What's our riskiest assumption right now?", and what your records say

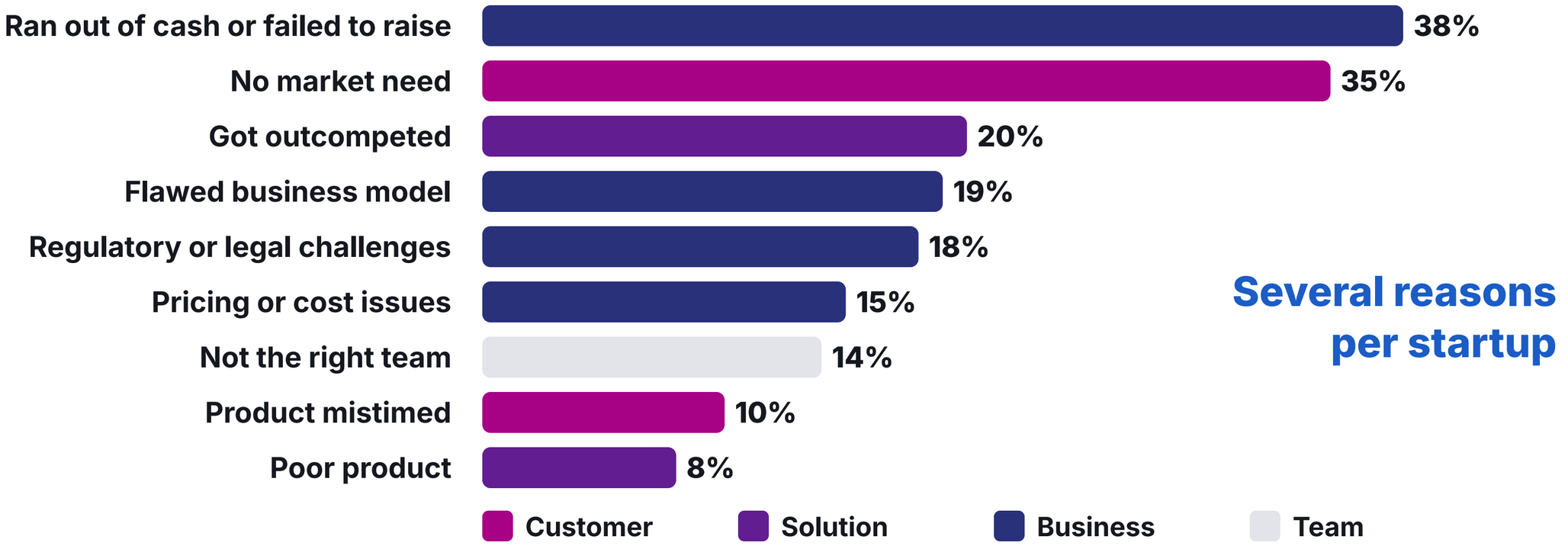
Kickoff (M00)	Team (M01)	Finding ideas (M02)	Problem space (M03)	Validating problems (M04)	Solution space (M05)	Prototyping (M06)	The kill decision (M07)
HR loses good finalists	We can sell to HR	It happens every week	HR tracks it by hand	HR signs up for alerts	Recruiters want a nudge	They use it alone	?
✓ Heard, 4 of 10	? Never tested	✓ Heard weekly	✓ €300 a month	✗ 9 of 140, line crossed	✓ 6 of 15 accepted	✓ 14 of 31	Your verdict

ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture, Weekly Reflection and Kill Criteria Log of the Student Toolkit.

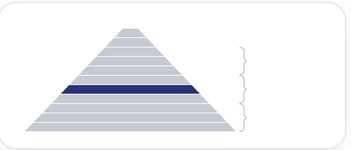
WHY STARTUPS DIE

Startups rarely die of one thing

% of 111 post-mortems since 2018 naming each reason, coloured by area



DATA CB Insights, "The top 12 reasons startups fail", 3 August 2021, 111 post-mortems, top 9 of 12 shown. Colours are the course's grouping.



TRANSLATE · MADE UP

Every cause of death is an assumption

About the customer, the solution or the business

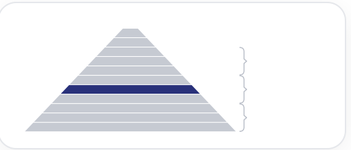
R.I.P.

Our startup
one year from now

Cause of death?

CUSTOMER	SOLUTION	BUSINESS
CAUSE "Nobody pays"	CAUSE "They stop using it"	CAUSE "We can't reach them"
ASSUMPTION **Recruiters pay €49 a month for a nudge**	ASSUMPTION **A nudge a day keeps finalists from going quiet**	ASSUMPTION **Recruiter groups bring us customers**

ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture. The three areas follow the learning goals of The kill decision (M07).



CHECK · MADE UP

Keep only what your records have not ruled out

- ✓ **Recruiters want to know when a finalist goes quiet**
  "An hour, not a week", heard in 9 demos
- ✓ **They use the nudge without help**
  Use Log, 14 of 31 reached the outcome alone
- ? **Recruiters pay €49 a month, every month**
  One deposit, Solution space (M05)
- ? **We reach recruiters through their groups**
  Traffic Sources, 9 of 140 signed up
- ? **Finalists answer a WhatsApp nudge**
  No artifact

Student Toolkit · our team · shared with 3 founders

I37 *fx* =COUNTIFS(H5:H35,"yes",I5:I35,"yes")

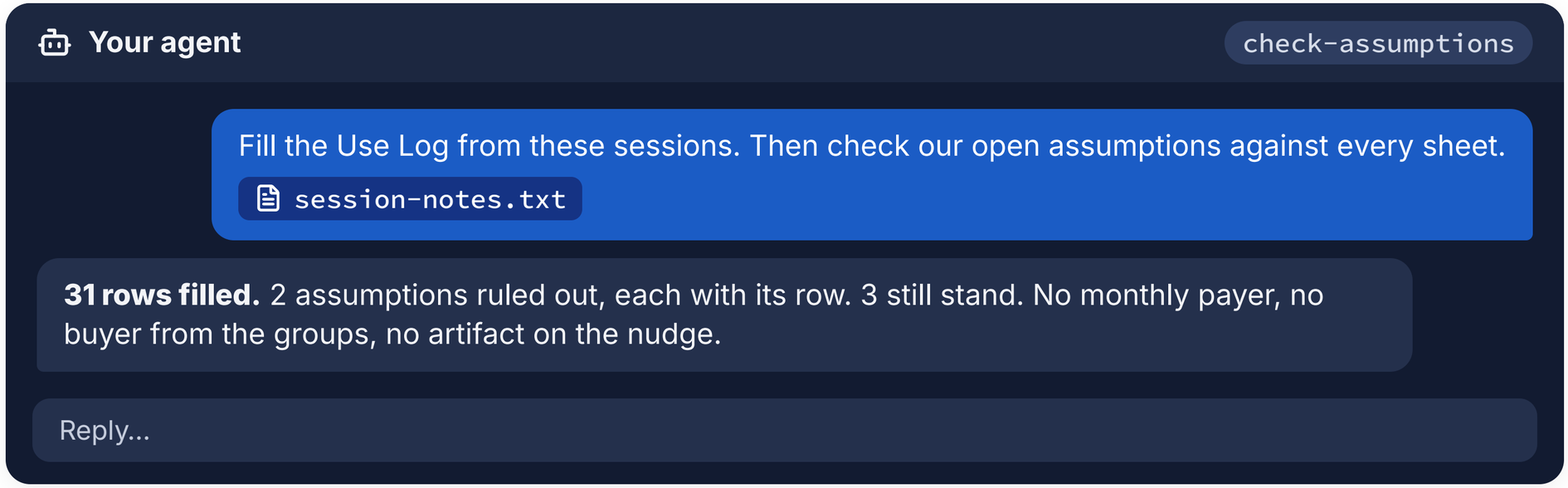
	C	D	E	H	I	K
4	**User (name)**	**Role and segment**	**Segment? (yes, mixed, no)**	**Used without help? (yes, no)**	**Reached the outcome? (yes, no)**	**What stopped them**
5	Lena M.	Recruiter, 120 staff	yes	yes	yes	
6	Aylin K.	Agency recruiter	mixed	no	no	Can't add a finalist
7	Jonas B.	HR lead, 60 staff	yes	yes	no	Team uses no Slack
8	Mira S.	Recruiter, 200 staff	yes	yes	yes	
9	Paul W.	Recruiter, 45 staff	yes	no	yes	Asked us on chat
…	…	26 more rows	…	…	…	
37	**Reached the outcome alone**				**14 of 31**	

Interview Log | Traffic Sources | **Use Log** | Assumptions | Kill Criteria Log

ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up venture, sheet prototyped for this course. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Keep only what your records have not ruled out



NOW YOU · ALONE · 3 MINUTES

Write your obituary



Imagine One year from now. Your venture is dead.

Write Three causes of death, alone

Translate Each into an assumption you can test

3:00

OUTPUT

Three assumptions per founder

Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.

INPUT 1 OF 4 · LIST IT · THE ANSWERS

List it: every cause of death is an assumption

1

What turns an assumption into a hypothesis?

It can fail. A hypothesis is an assumption you can prove wrong

2

How do you find the assumptions you rely on?

Imagine your venture dead in a year and write down why

3

Which of them still matter?

Only those your records have not ruled out yet

Rank it: the monkey first

Sort what is left by critical and known, and test the critical unknown first.

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INPUT 2 OF 4 · RANK IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Which assumption do you test first?

1



Which assumption goes first?

2



How do you write it down?

3



How do you test it?

Let's say you're trying to teach a monkey how to recite Shakespeare while on a pedestal.

Astro Teller, head of X, the moonshot factory, 2016

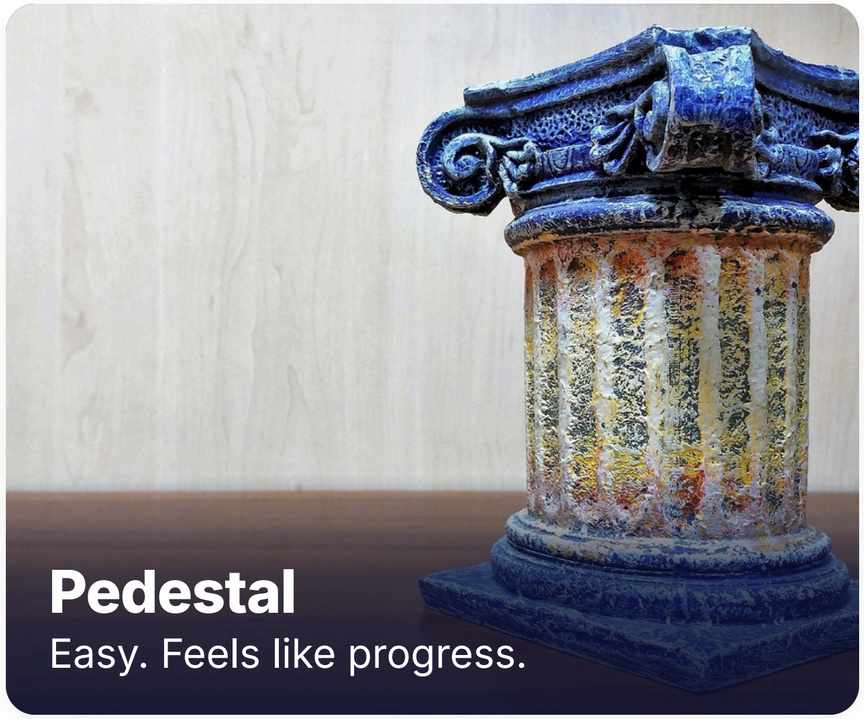
X, formerly Google X



MONKEY FIRST

Train the monkey, skip the pedestal

The monkey is the critical unknown. If it is false, nothing else matters



vs.

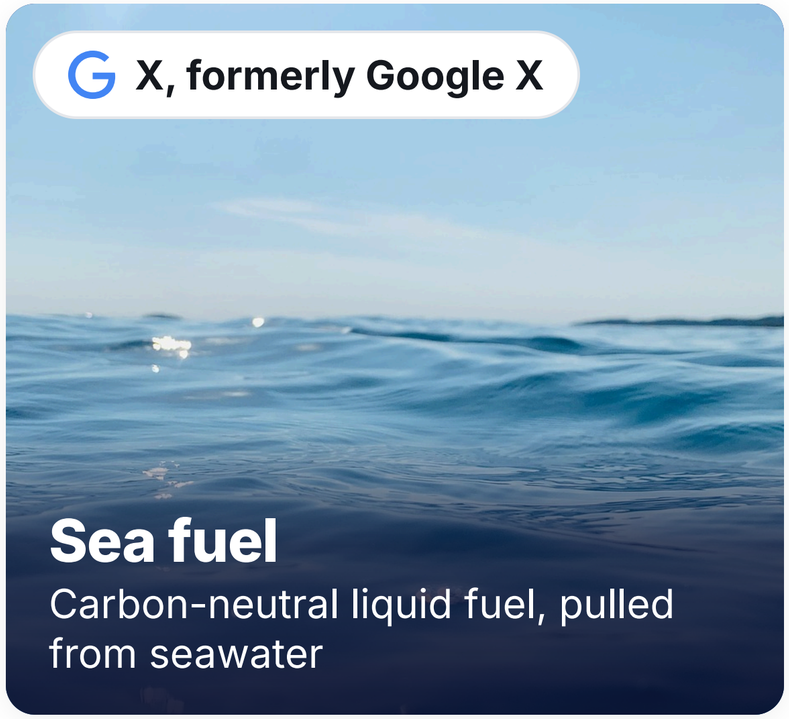


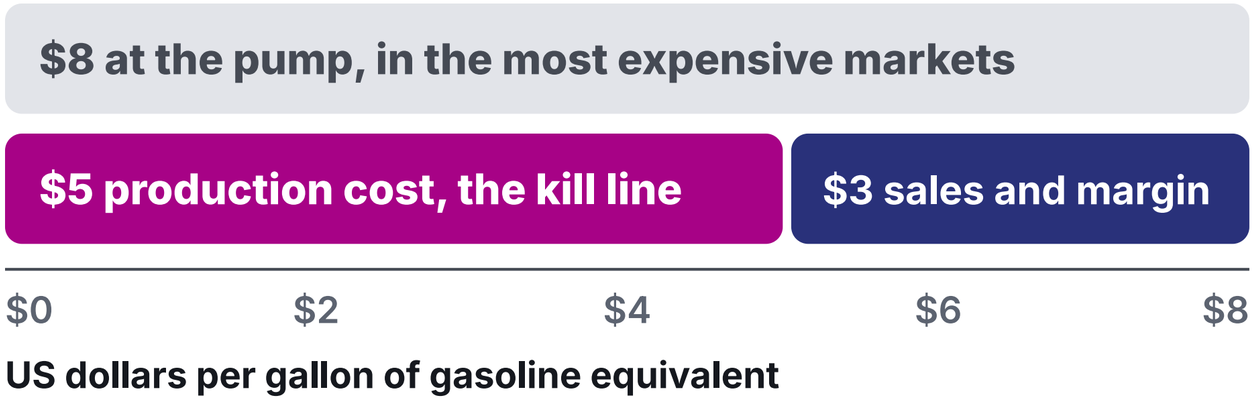
FRAMEWORK Teller (2016), "Tackle the monkey first", X blog. Photos: Crava_Emanuele and a_m_o_u_t_o_n on Pixabay.

TELLER'S OWN EXAMPLE · PROJECT FOGHORN

The fuel worked. The price was the monkey

Its kill line, set at the start, said $5 per gallon equivalent within 5 years





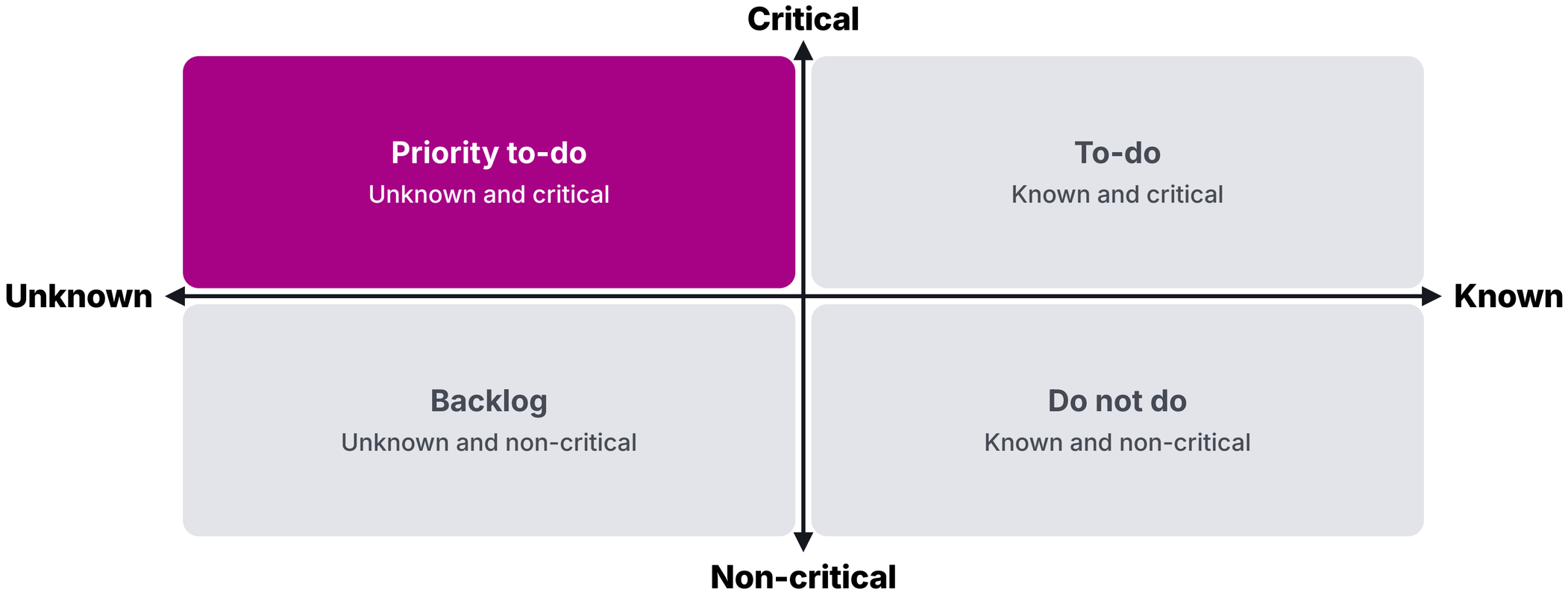
The fuel worked
In the lab, a relatively straightforward task

January 2016, killed
After two years, half of the work spent on the cost model

FRAMEWORK Teller (2016), Hannun (2016), both X blog. Bars to scale. Photo: janchrhorn on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

HYPOTHESIS MAPPING

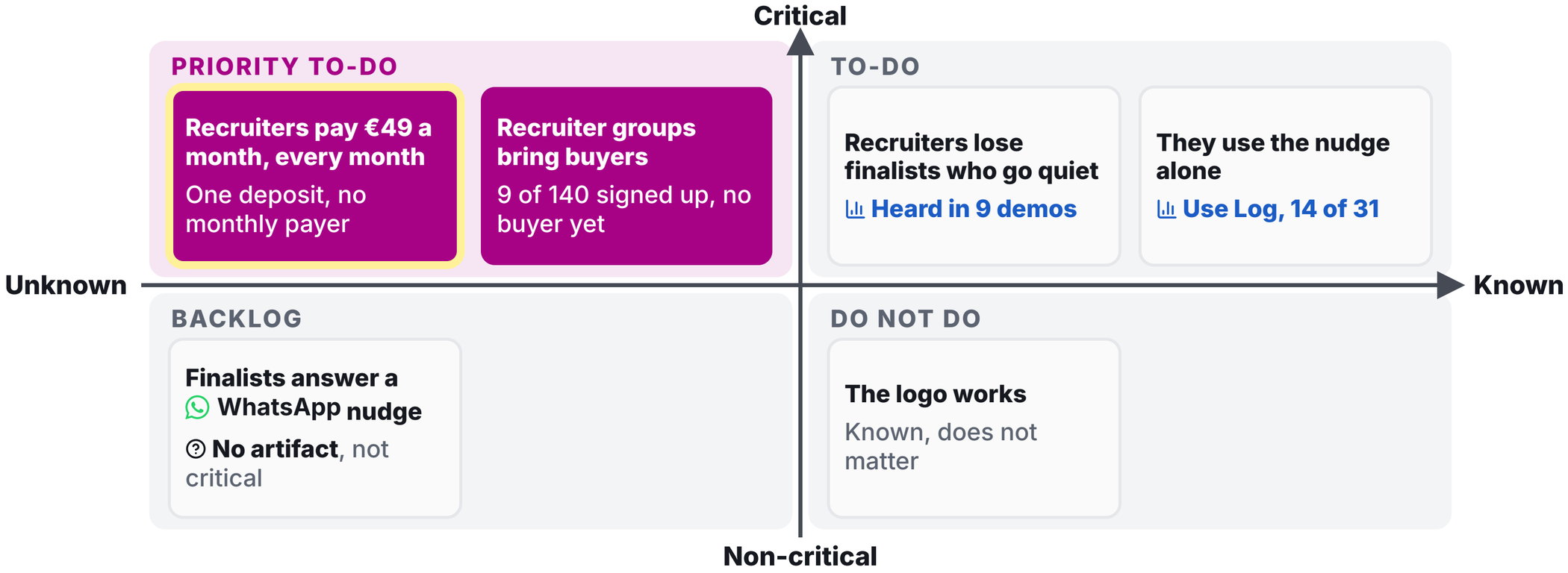
Critical and unknown goes first



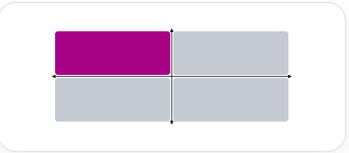
MAP IT · MADE UP

Known means an artifact shows it

Two critical unknowns. The first is the monkey



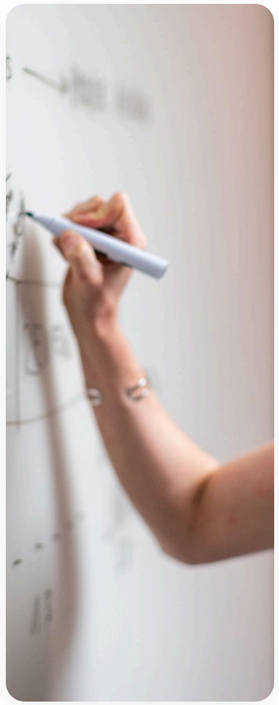
ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture, the assumptions from the check slide, mapped. Logos are trademarks of their owners.



FORMULATE · MADE UP

Write it so it can fail

Specific, testable, actionable



WE BELIEVE THAT	**Recruiters who used the nudge pay €49 a month for it, every month**
TO VERIFY, WE WILL	**Each of us asks 10 of them to sign a €49-a-month pre-order**
WE'RE RIGHT IF	**At least 3 of the first 10 sign by the First users (M08) check-in**
DECISION	**If not, our verdict drops one step**

ILLUSTRATIVE Test card after Bland and Osterwalder (2019), Testing Business Ideas, as in Validating problems (M04). Example made up. Photo: This_is_Engineering on Pixabay.

HOW-TO · SKILLS, NOT PROMPTS · MADE UP

A skill turns feedback into hypotheses

Output wrong? Fix the skill, not the output. Every number stays your bet

`skills/feedback-to-hypotheses.md`

Steps. List each assumption in the raw notes. Rewrite each with a count and a date.

Rule. Quote who said it. Mark every number as our bet.

✓ **Good.** At least 3 of the first 10 recruiters sign a €49-a-month pre-order by the next check-in.

× **Weak.** Recruiters like the nudge.

Check. Could it come back with a no?

Your agent `feedback-to-hypotheses`

Run it on the demo notes. `demo-notes.txt`

3 hypotheses, every number is your bet. 3 of the first 10 name a finalist they lost. 3 of the first 10 sign a €49 pre-order. 1 of 20 from a recruiter group books a demo.

We count buyers, not demos. Change the skill.

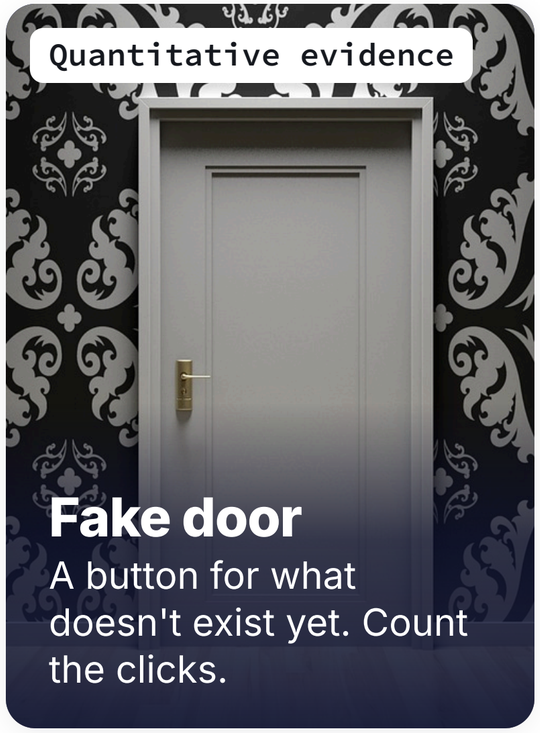
Skill updated. A channel hypothesis now counts buyers.

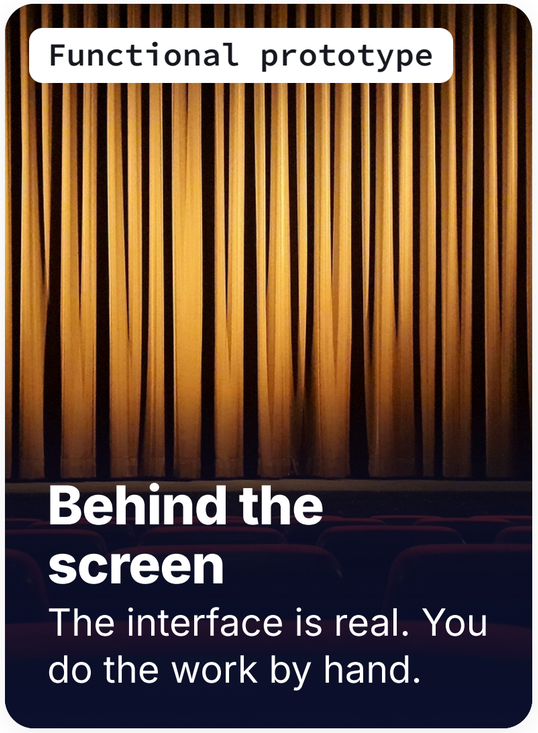
ILLUSTRATIVE Skill and chat prototyped for this course, demo notes and numbers made up.

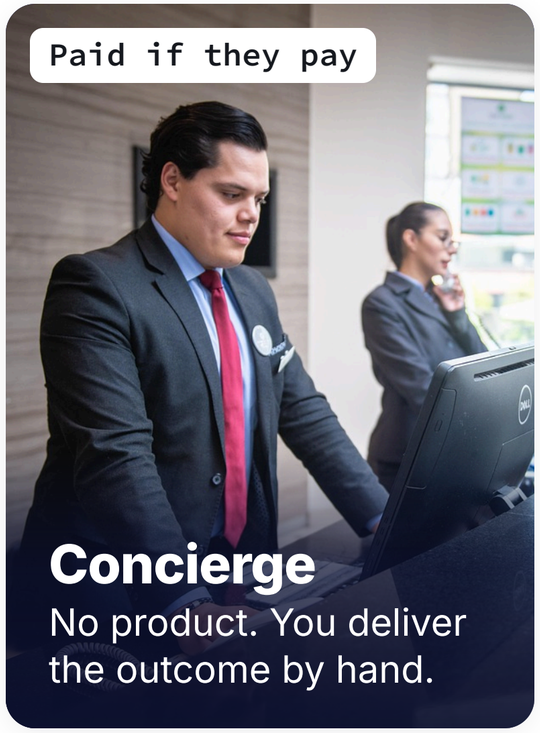
TEST CHEAPLY

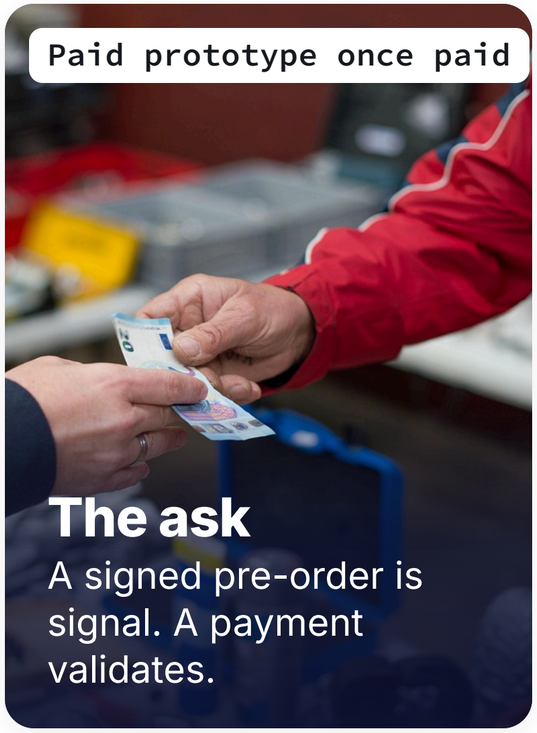
Pick the cheapest test that could prove it wrong

Cheaper is better, as long as it could kill the monkey



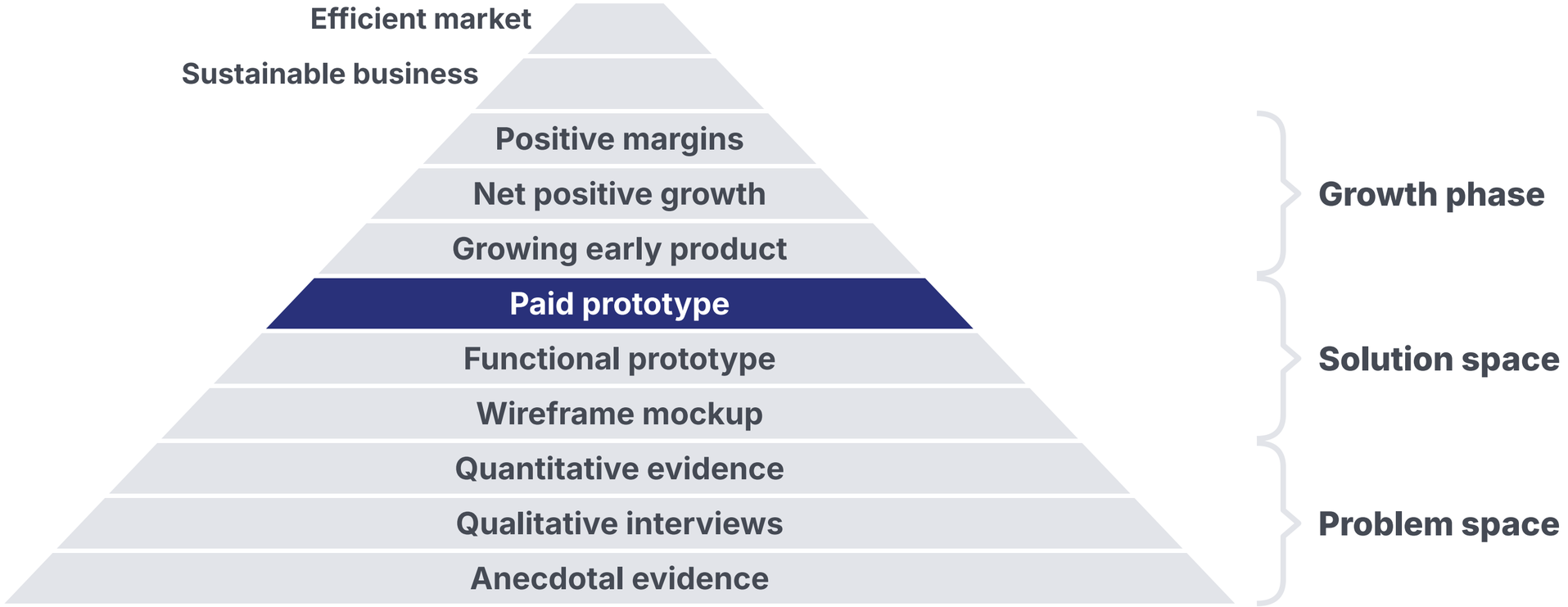


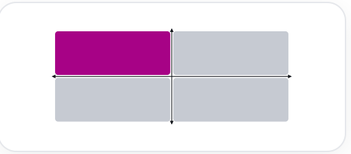




RUNG SIX

Will they pay? Then ask for money

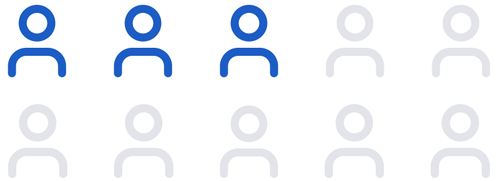




WRITE THE LINE FIRST · THE HOMEWORK DEFAULT

Log the line before the first result

If fewer than 3 of the first 10 people from our segment do what our monkey assumes by the Module 08 check-in, it is false. A Go becomes a Pivot, a Pivot a Kill, and a restart picks a new offer.



3 of the first 10

Experiment	Pre-committed threshold	Actual result	Committed before?
Monkey, €49 a month	Fewer than 3 of the first 10 sign, verdict drops a step	running	✓ **yes**

ILLUSTRATIVE Default kill line, The kill decision (M07) homework, after framework 02. Row from the made-up venture's Kill Criteria Log.

NOW YOU · TEAM · 3 MINUTES · DON'T OVERDO IT

Map your assumptions. Circle the monkey



Critical? If false, does the venture die?

Known? Which artifact shows it?

Monkey Critical and unknown. Circle one

3:00

OUTPUT

One monkey per team

Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.

INPUT 2 OF 4 · RANK IT · THE ANSWERS

Rank it: train the monkey, skip the pedestal

1

Which assumption goes first?

The monkey, critical and unknown. If it is false, nothing else matters

2

How do you write it down?

So it can fail. Specific, testable, actionable, with its line logged first

3

How do you test it?

With the cheapest test that could prove it wrong. Will they pay? Ask for money

Judge it: your past self decides

Let the lines you wrote decide first, then score the rest on artifacts.

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INPUT 3 OF 4 · JUDGE IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Who decides your verdict?

1



What decides first?

2



What decides the rest?

3



How final is the verdict?

ACCOUNTABLE DECISIONS · MADE UP

Every decision should be accountable

Tinted rows crossed their line. The team did what it said

Student Toolkit · Kill Criteria Log

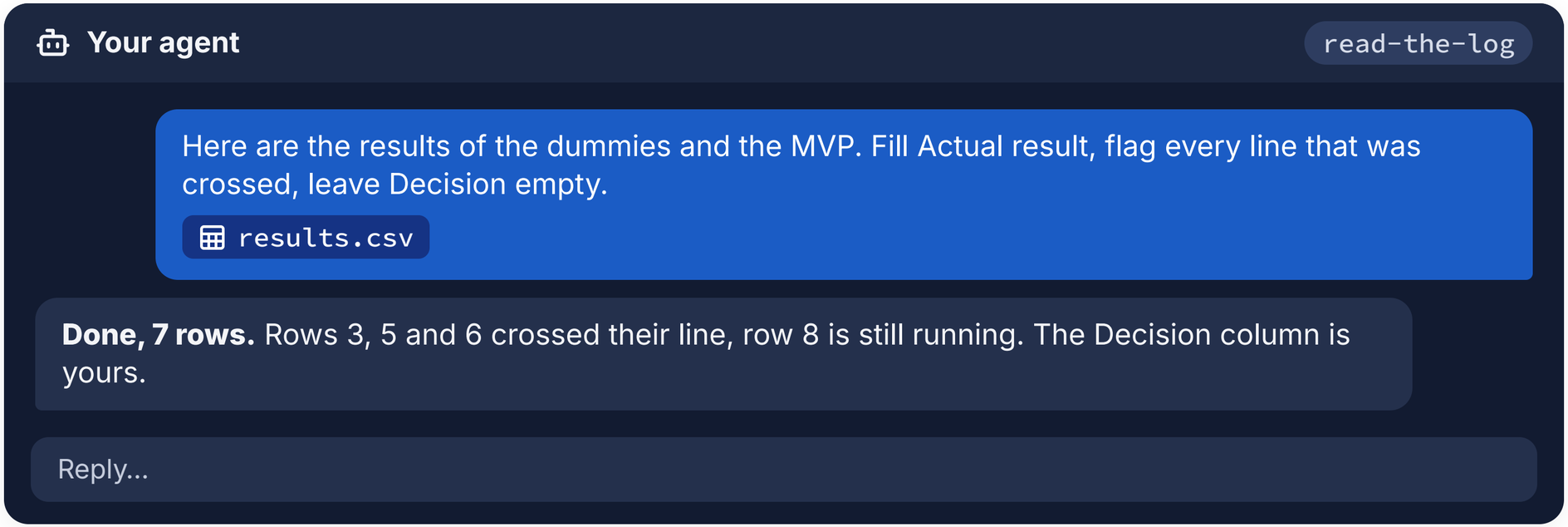
	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	**Module**	**Experiment**	**Pre-committed pass/fail threshold**	**Actual result**	**Decision (go/pivot/kill)**	**Committed BEFORE the test? (yes/no)**
2	Problem space (M03)	Problem interviews	Fewer than 3 of 10 raise it unprompted, switch segment	4 of 10	go	yes
3	Validating problems (M04)	Landing page	Under 10% of segment visitors sign up, switch segment	9 of 140	pivot	yes
4	Solution space (M05)	Dummy A, the nudge	Fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it	6 of 15	go	yes
5	Solution space (M05)	Dummy B, a dashboard	Fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it	1 of 15	kill	yes
6	Solution space (M05)	Dummy C, a weekly report	Fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it	1 of 15	kill	yes
7	Prototyping (M06)	Live MVP	Fewer than 3 of the first 10 reach the outcome, rebuild	14 of 31	go	yes
8	The kill decision (M07)	Monkey: €49 a month	Fewer than 3 of the first 10 sign, verdict drops a step	running		yes

Experiment Tracker | Use Log | Assumptions | **Kill Criteria Log** | Verdict

ILLUSTRATIVE A made-up team's Kill Criteria Log, columns as in the Student Toolkit. Screen prototyped for this course.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Every decision should be accountable



Kill signals [are] metrics that a team agrees on when the project starts.

Astro Teller on X, the moonshot factory, 2016

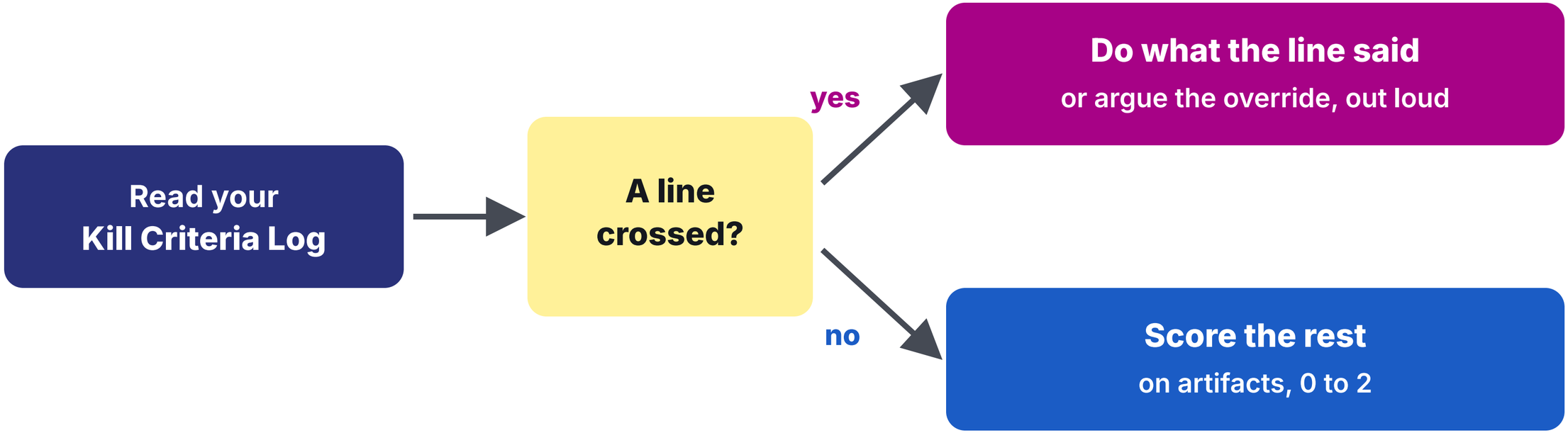
X, formerly Google X

Foghorn's signal read **$5 per gallon equivalent within 5 years.**

DECIDE · STEP 1

Your Kill Criteria Log decides first

The scorecard only scores what the log leaves open



DECIDE · STEP 2 · CLICK ALONG

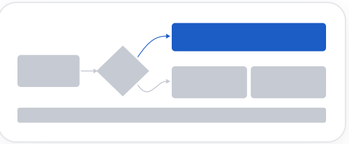
Score nine questions on artifacts

No artifact scores 0. That is a finding, not a missed week

PROBLEM · MAX 6				SOLUTION · MAX 6				TRACTION · MAX 6			
1	Raised unprompted?	0 1 2		4	Used without help?	0 1 2		7	Anyone paid?	0 1 2	
2	Workaround spend?	0 1 2		5	10 times better?	0 1 2		8	Came back alone?	0 1 2	
3	At least weekly?	0 1 2		6	Why now?	0 1 2		9	Growing weekly?	0 1 2	



FRAMEWORK GPK Decision Framework, framework 03, step 2. Zones as in the GPK scorecard exemplar.



WORKED EXAMPLE · MADE UP

14 of 18. A Go, at the edge

No open line crossed, so the score decides. One deposit is not yet a business

PROBLEM · MAX 6		SOLUTION · MAX 6		TRACTION · MAX 6	
1 Raised unprompted?	1	4 Used without help?	2	7 Anyone paid?	2
2 Workaround spend?	2	5 10 times better?	2	8 Came back alone?	2
3 At least weekly?	2	6 Why now?	1	9 Growing weekly?	0



ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture of the earlier sessions, scored with framework 03.

NOW YOU · PAIRS · 3 MINUTES

Score two questions on your own artifacts



Question 7 Has anyone paid? Which artifact?

Question 8 Did users come back alone? Which rows?

Score 0, 1 or 2, and why

3:00

OUTPUT

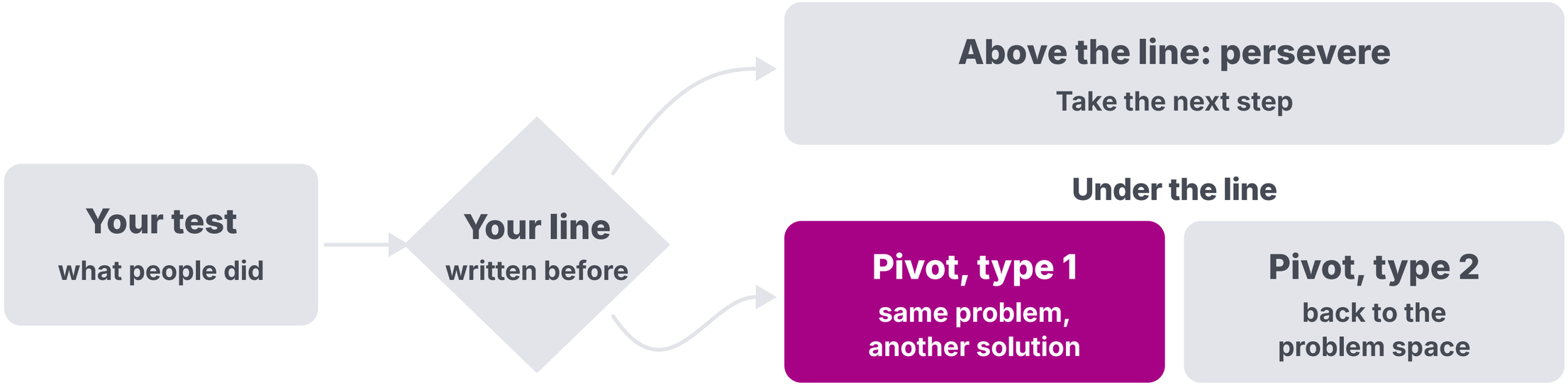
Two scores, each with its artifact

Photo: sasint on Pixabay.

PIVOTING · RE-SHOWN FROM SOLUTION SPACE (M05)

Type 1: another solution to the same problem

Solution or traction weak, problem strong. X's cars, today Waymo, did this



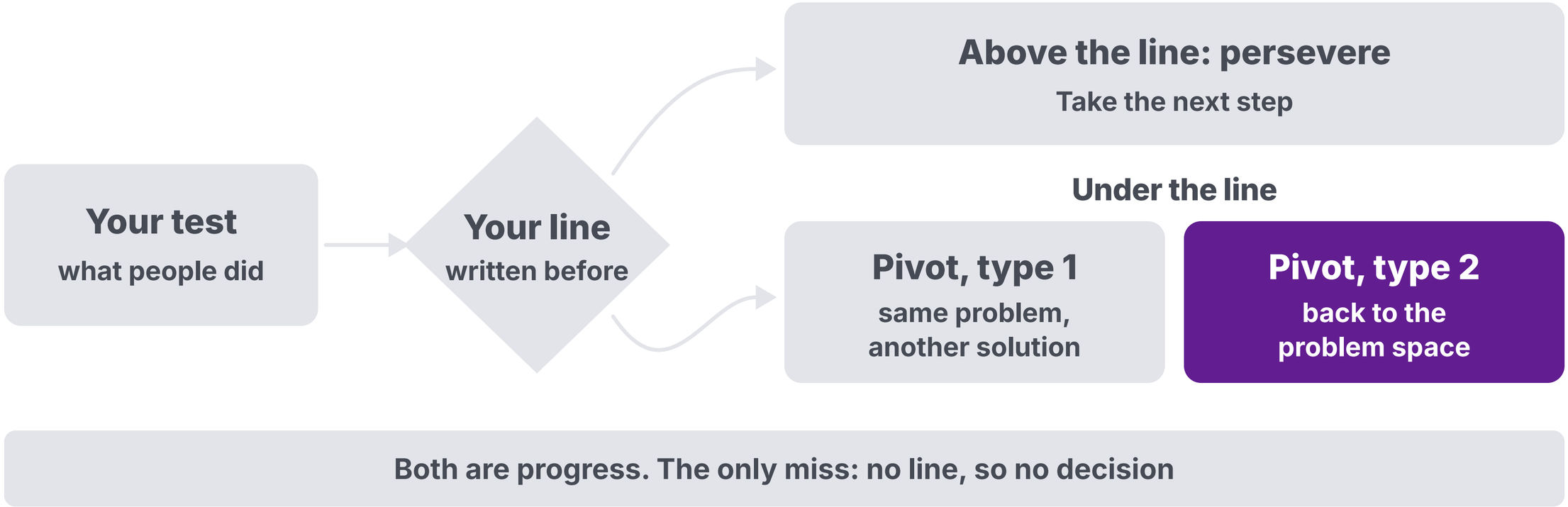
Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK After Ries (2011), The Lean Startup. X's cars in Teller (2016), TED2016, 05:15. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

PIVOTING · RE-SHOWN FROM SOLUTION SPACE (M05)

Type 2: back to the problem space

Problem weak



FRAMEWORK After Ries (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

THE GO QUESTION

Will this be your office in 3 to 5 years?



Build this
for years?

DECIDE · STEP 3

Today's verdict is provisional

Announce it out loud, then let the monkey test confirm it



Today

Provisional verdict, the line logged

Until then

Monkey test, 10 people each

Next check-in

Result next to line. Confirmed or changed

FRAMEWORK GPK Decision Framework, framework 03, step 3. Photo: This_is_Engineering on Pixabay.

QUICK ASK · HANDS

Which line in your log did you cross?

1:00

INPUT 3 OF 4 · JUDGE IT · THE ANSWERS

Judge it: the log first, then the scorecard

1

What decides first?

Your Kill Criteria Log, the lines you wrote before the data

2

What decides the rest?

Nine questions, scored on artifacts. No artifact scores 0

3

How final is the verdict?

Provisional. Say it out loud, then let the monkey test confirm it

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CHAPTER 6 OF 10

Close it: kill well, then restart

Write down what the evidence said, then restart from your own records.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~List it: every way it could die~~
04 ~~Rank it: the monkey first~~
05 ~~Judge it: your past self decides~~
06 **Close it: kill well, then restart**
07 Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter
08 Wrap-up and check-out
09 Workshop: kill your darlings
10 Case discussion

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CLOSE IT · THREE QUESTIONS

How do you kill well?

1



Why is a kill so hard?

2



How do you kill well?

3



What comes after a kill?

We have bonused every single person on teams that ended their projects.

Astro Teller, TED2016

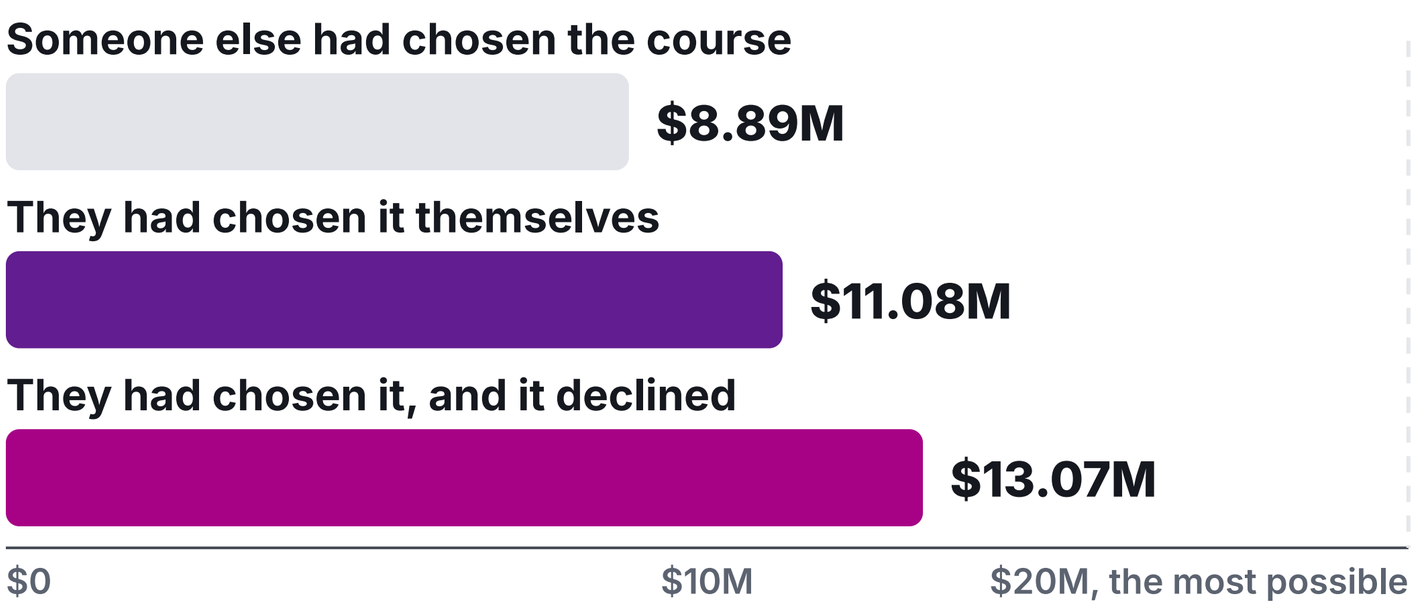
X, formerly Google X



ESCALATION OF COMMITMENT

The more it is yours, the harder you hold on

Average R&D money put back into a course of action, 240 business students



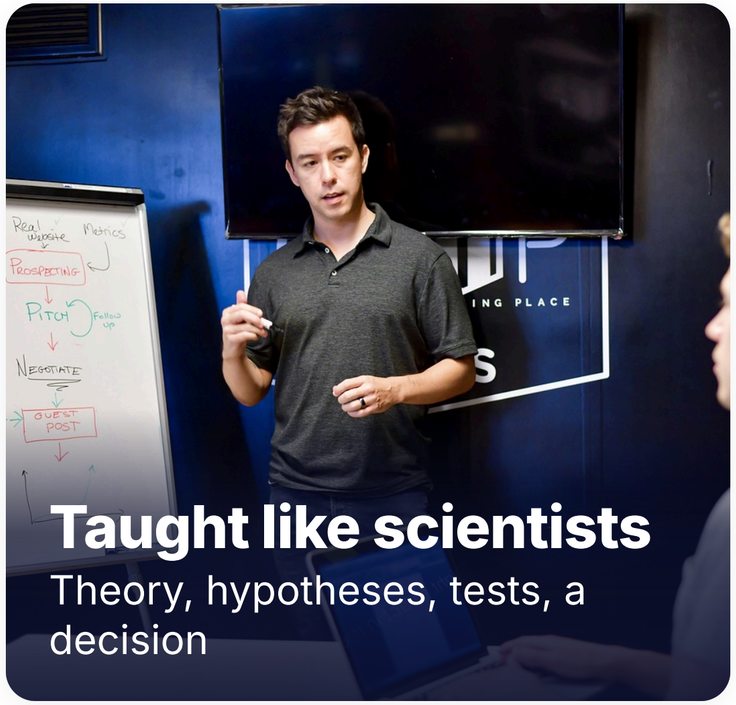


RESEARCH Staw (1976), "Knee-deep in the big muddy", a role-play with 240 business school students. Photo: Myriams-Fotos on Pixabay.

DOES IT PAY · FOUR RANDOMISED TRIALS

Founders who test stop sooner and earn more

759 early-stage firms in Milan, Turin and London, in randomised trials



Taught like scientists

Theory, hypotheses, tests, a decision

+9.8 percentage points more ended their project

2.7 weeks earlier, on average

+€7,000 revenue on average, by the last interview

RESEARCH Camuffo et al. (2024), Strategic Management Journal 45(6), after a first trial with 116 Italian startups. Photo: DiggityMarketing on Pixabay.

THE KILL RITUAL

One page turns a kill into an asset

A rigorously argued kill can earn an A in this course

1. **What the evidence said**
   With the artifacts. Not "it didn't work".
2. **Which line it crossed**
   From your Kill Criteria Log, with its date.
3. **What surprised us**
   The finding nobody expected.
4. **What we'd tell the next founder**
   Three sentences.

FRAMEWORK GPK Decision Framework, framework 03, the Kill Ritual. Grading Rubric, "The A-Kill". Glossary, "KILL".

WORKED EXAMPLE · MADE UP

Kill what fell under its line

Student Toolkit · our team · shared with 3 founders

F3 *fx* kill

	C	D	E	F	G
1	**Experiment**	**Pre-committed pass/fail threshold**	**Actual result**	**Decision (go/ pivot/kill)**	**Committed BEFORE the test? (yes/no)**
2	Click dummy A, the morning alert	Fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it	3 of the first 7 accepted	go	yes
3	Click dummy B, the dashboard	Fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it	0 of the first 7, 1 of 15 in all	kill	yes
4					

Use Log | Assumptions | **Kill Criteria Log** | Verdict

KILLED

Team drive · Kill pages · click dummy B

Normal text | B | I | U | Comments 2 | Share

KILL RITUAL · ONE PAGE

Kill page · click dummy B, the dashboard

Killed in Solution space (M05) · linked in the Verdict sheet

1. Evidence. 0 of the first 7 accepted the dashboard's ask, 1 of 15 in all. Three asked for the alert without it.

2. Line crossed. Solution space (M05), "fewer than 2 of the first 7 accept the ask, drop it", logged before the first demo.

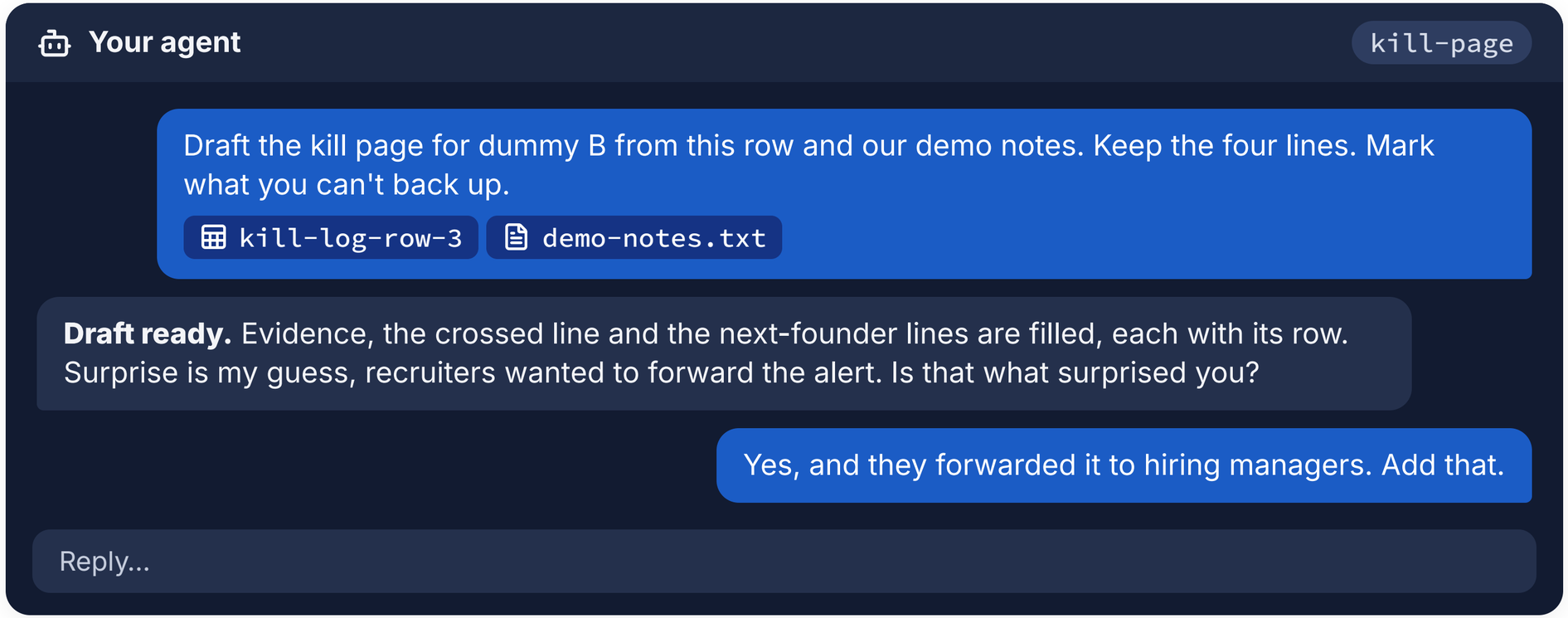
3. Surprise. Recruiters wanted to forward the alert to their hiring managers.

4. Next founder. Show the one outcome first. A dashboard is where you hide from the question. Watch what people forward.

ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture, a Kill Ritual page for a feature and its Kill Criteria Log row, prototyped for this course.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Kill what fell under its line



ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture, a Kill Ritual page for a feature and its Kill Criteria Log row, prototyped for this course.

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

Write one surprise



Pick Something your team already dropped

Write What surprised you about it

Share One per team, out loud

2:00

OUTPUT

One surprise per founder

Photo: congerdesign on Pixabay.

RESTART

Killed? Restart from your own records

Seven weeks produced problems, segments and channels. Use them



Your records
Interviews, Pain Map, sign-ups, Use Log, channels

Strongest asset
Often a channel or a segment, not the product

Concierge offer
The outcome, delivered by hand, with a price

Named people
10 from your records to offer it to



EXEMPLAR · MADE UP

The kill was not the end of the company

KILLED

0 of 9

asked students paid for AI exam prep, line 3 of 10

STRONGEST ASSET

12.9%

click rate in the student council channel

CONCIERGE RESTART

€29

a 4-week exam sprint by hand, 30 seats

BY DEMO DAY

23

seats sold, €667

ILLUSTRATIVE A-grade kill autopsy exemplar, team Klausurly, a synthetic example in the course resources. Photo: Pexels on Pixabay.

FIRST USERS (M08) IS FOR EVERYONE

Go, Pivot or Kill,



everyone asks for money

Go and Pivot teams sell what the verdict kept.

Killed teams sell the concierge version.

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CLOSE IT · THE ANSWERS

Close it: a kill is an asset

1

Why is a kill so hard?

The more it is yours, the harder you hold on

2

How do you kill well?

With the Kill Ritual, one page on what the evidence said

3

What comes after a kill?

A restart from your own records, its problems, segments, channels

CHAPTER 7 OF 10

Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter

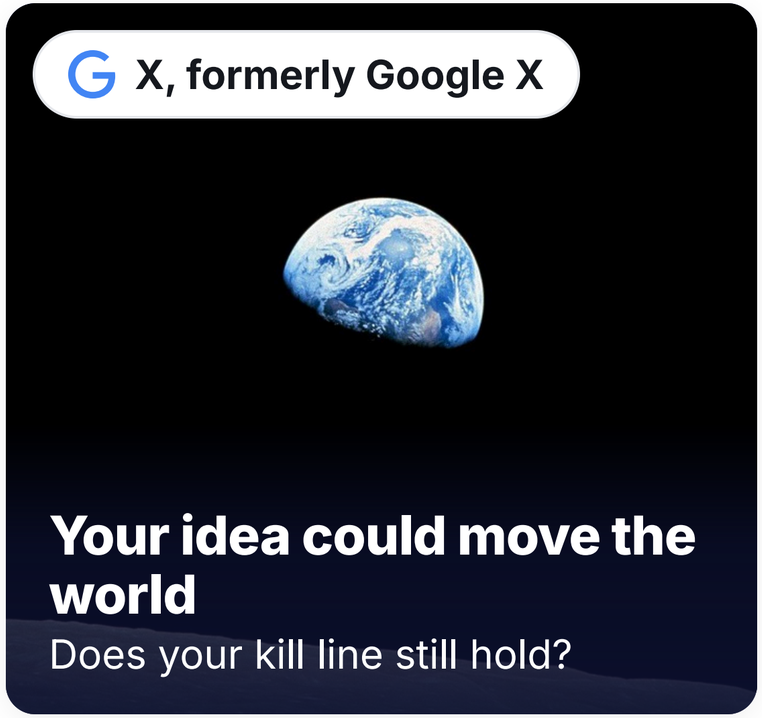
Test the method on a moonshot, then find it again in your product work.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~List it: every way it could die~~
04 ~~Rank it: the monkey first~~
05 ~~Judge it: your past self decides~~
06 ~~Close it: kill well, then restart~~
07 **Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter**
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09 Workshop: kill your darlings
10 Case discussion

ZOOM OUT · THINK BIG

The bigger the idea, the earlier X tries to kill it

Problems of millions or billions, sci-fi technology, 5 to 10 years



Hundreds of ideas last a few hours

Dozens a few weeks

Handfuls months, and half of the last stage is killed

"How are we going to kill our project today?"

HANDS FIRST

It holds

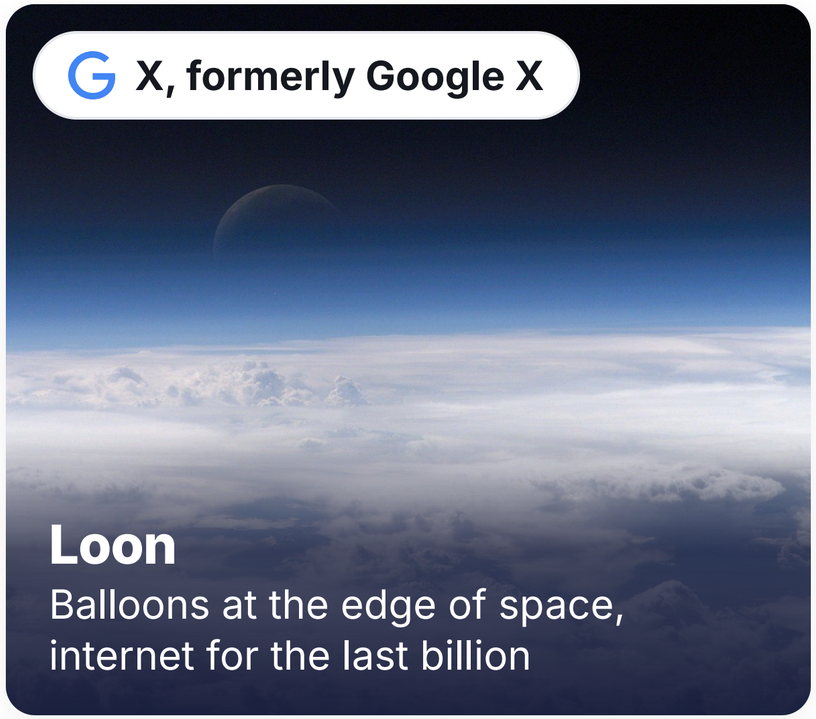
It needs adapting

FRAMEWORK Teller (2016), operating manual, Teller (2016), TED2016. Bars show the order of magnitude, not counts. Photo: WikiImages on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

ZOOM OUT · LOON

Loon beat physics. The business killed it

Nine years. Each step could have killed it, the last one did



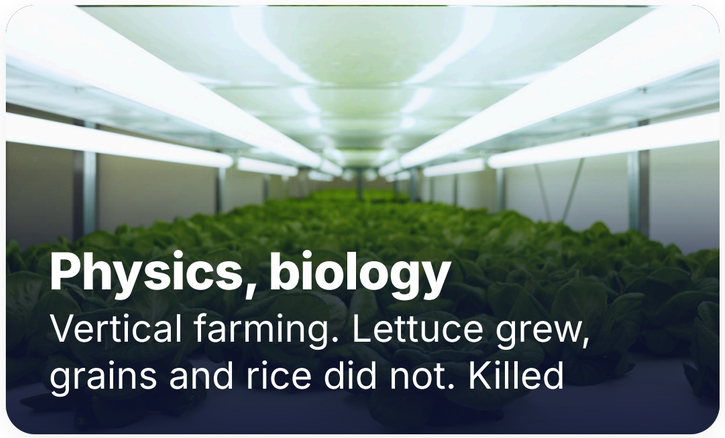
- ✓ Wi-Fi from the stratosphere to an antenna
- ✓ Straight to handsets
- ✓ Up to 15 megabits per second
- ✓ Balloons that talk to each other
- ✓ Over 100 days aloft, under 5% of the old cost
- ✓ Steered to within 500 m after 20,000 km
- ✗ **A business, "much longer and riskier than hoped"**

FRAMEWORK Teller (2016), TED2016. Teller (2021), "Loon's final flight". Photo: WikiImages on Pixabay, the sky, not Loon. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

ZOOM OUT · WHAT CHANGES

At world size, the monkey is rarely a sign-up

Keep the rule. Expect another monkey and a longer clock



Physics, biology
Vertical farming. Lettuce grew, grains and rice did not. Killed



The first test
Cargo airship. $200 million for the first data point. Killed



The regulator
Wing. Six years and 70,000 test flights to the first drone air carrier certificate

Stays
The line before the data. The hardest part first. A reward for walking away.

Changes
The first test costs weeks and thousands, never millions. The date moves out by years. Budget unlocks per risk that falls.



ZOOM OUT · PRODUCT WORK

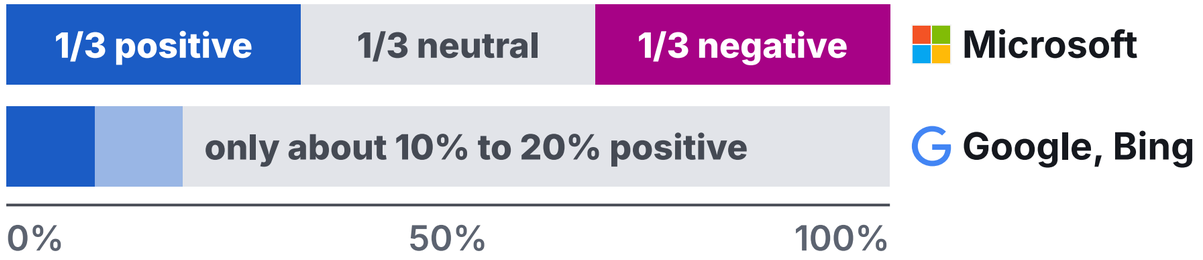
In product work, this decision comes back every quarter

Per initiative, on a line written when it started

ONE VENTURE, ONE YEAR LATER · MADE UP

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
Morning nudge	Go	Go	Go	Go
Group channel	Go	Pivot	Go	Kill
Team seats	·	Go	Pivot	Go
Calendar link	Go	Kill	·	·

WHY IT KEEPS COMING BACK



Share of experiments by result, over 10,000 a year per company

Product management (M10) makes each one a bet with its expected effect, read every week

CHAPTER 8 OF 10

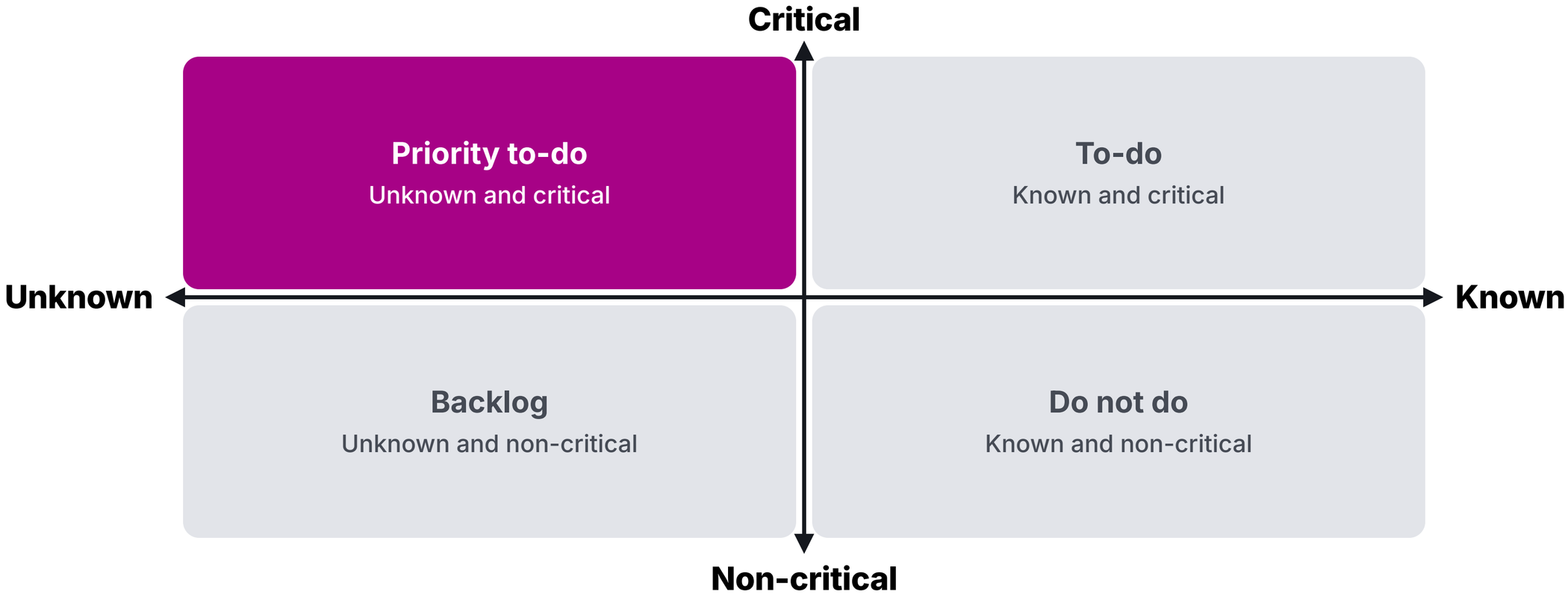
Wrap-up and check-out

Two pictures to keep, three questions to reflect on, and your week.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~List it: every way it could die~~
04 ~~Rank it: the monkey first~~
05 ~~Judge it: your past self decides~~
06 ~~Close it: kill well, then restart~~
07 ~~Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter~~
08 **Wrap-up and check-out**
09 Workshop: kill your darlings
10 Case discussion

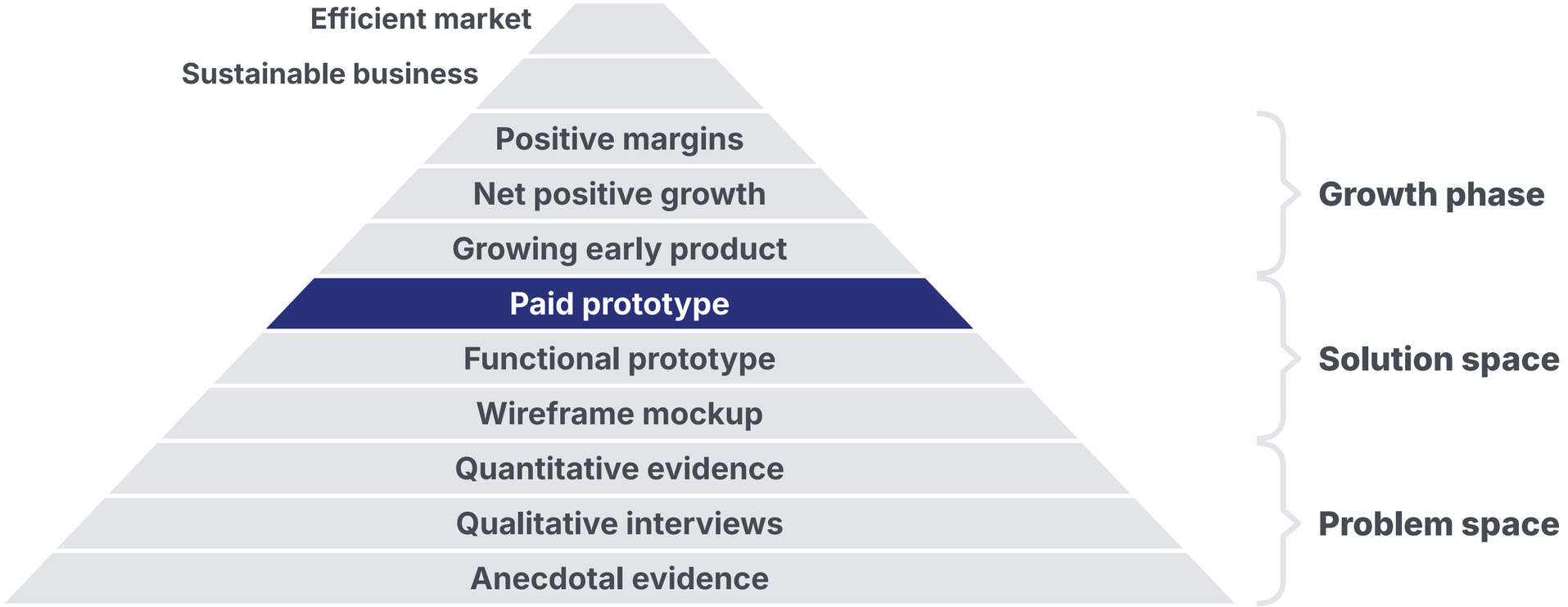
RECAP · TODAY

Test the critical unknown first



RECAP · RUNGS FIVE AND SIX

From today you test at the wallet line



REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



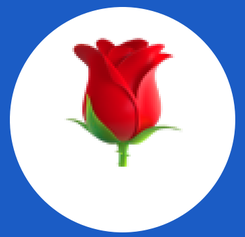
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Test your monkey with 10 people per student from your segment against a line logged first, decide Go, Pivot or Kill on your Kill Criteria Log and scorecard, and bring the verdict and your next offer to the Module 08 check-in.

10 people each

The learning floor is the scored verdict and the offer per team and 5 such people per student.

Your line. Fewer than 3 of the first 10 do what your monkey assumes, and the verdict drops one step.

HOMEWORK · HOW TO DO IT

Write the obituary, then test the monkey

1. **Write the obituary.** Beside your Weekly Reflection. Each cause becomes an assumption.
2. **Find the monkey.** Critical and unknown, never a pedestal.
3. **Decide.** Crossed lines in your log first, the scorecard the rest.
4. **Run the cheapest test that could prove the monkey wrong,** people from your records first.

! **Watch out.** "Would you pay?" is not a test. A signed pre-order is.

5. **Killing?** Write the Kill Ritual page. Restart from your records with a concierge offer, the outcome by hand.
6. **Ask AI twice,** for assumptions from raw notes and a blind read of results. Remove hypothesis and names.
7. **Midweek.** Behind? Look elsewhere. Crossed? Step down now.

HOMEWORK · WHAT YOU COME BACK WITH

Good is tested, decided and priced

	GOOD	WEAK
MONKEY TEST	22 recruiters asked for a €49-a-month pre-order, 7 signed	3 friends said they'd pay
VERDICT	Go, confirmed against its line	"Still deciding"
OFFER	€49 a month, 14 named recruiters	"Launch on Product Hunt"

Sources in this deck

Bland, D. J., & Osterwalder, A. (2019). *Testing business ideas*. Wiley. Test card format.

Camuffo, A., Gambardella, A., Messinese, D., Novelli, E., Paolucci, E., & Spina, C. (2024). A scientific approach to entrepreneurial decision-making: Large-scale replication and extension. *Strategic Management Journal*, 45(6).

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Klein, G. (2007). Performing a project premortem. *Harvard Business Review*, September 2007.

Kohavi, R., & Thomke, S. (2017). The surprising power of online experiments. *Harvard Business Review*, 95(5), 74 to 82.

Ries, E. (2011). *The Lean Startup*. Crown Business. Excerpt: Pivot or persevere? *Entrepreneur*, 13 September 2011.

Sources in this deck

Staw, B. M. (1976). Knee-deep in the big muddy. *Organizational Behavior and Human Performance*, 16(1), 27 to 44.

Teller, A. (2016, February). *The unexpected benefit of celebrating failure*. TED2016.

Teller, A. (2016, July 23). *The moonshot factory operating manual*. X blog.

Teller, A. (2016, December 7). *Tackle the monkey first*. X blog.

Teller, A. (2021, January 22). *Loon's final flight*. X blog.

Wing (2019, April 23). *Wing becomes first certified Air Carrier for drones in the US*.

X, the moonshot factory. *Foghorn: Creating clean fuel from seawater*. Project page.

Course material: Glossary, Grading Rubric, frameworks 02 and 03, the A-grade kill autopsy exemplar (made up).

See you next time!

MODULE 07 · THE KILL DECISION · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

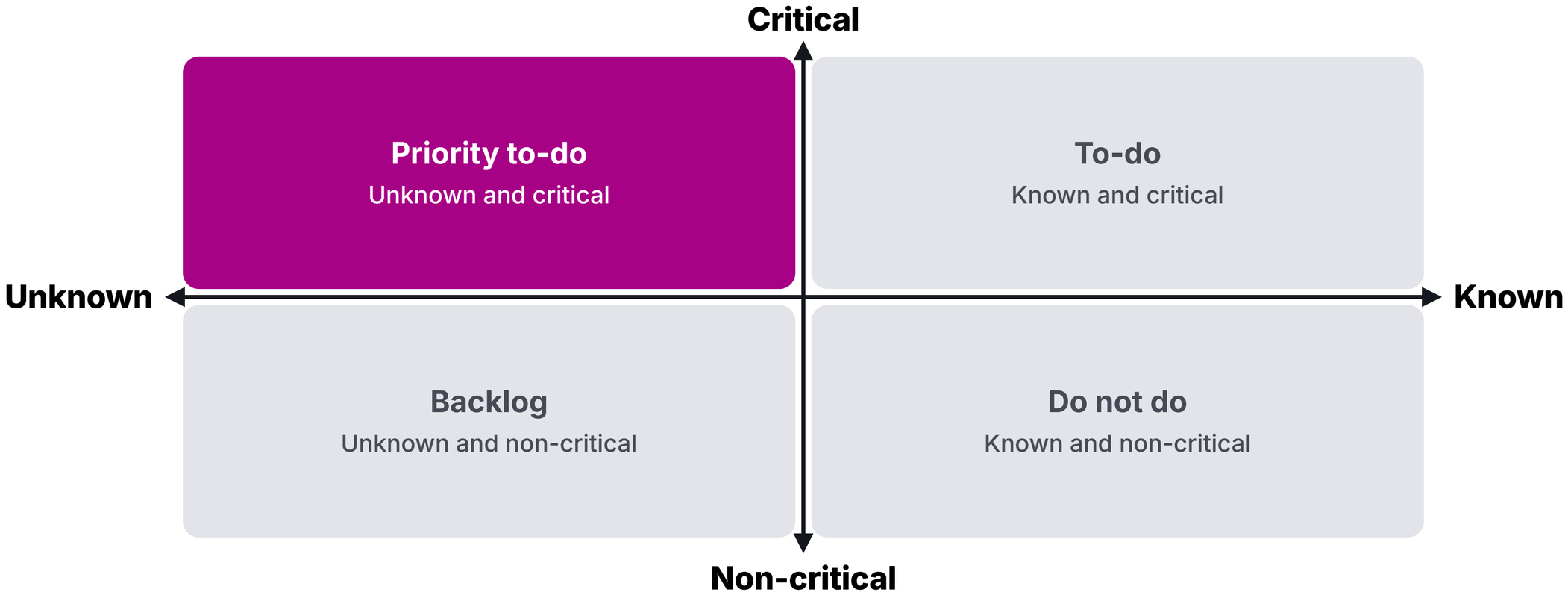
Workshop: Kill your darlings

Find out why this startup should die, from your records and the lines you wrote.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **List it: every way it could die**
04 **Rank it: the monkey first**
05 **Judge it: your past self decides**
06 **Close it: kill well, then restart**
07 Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter
08 Wrap-up and check-out
09 **Workshop: kill your darlings**
10 Case discussion

WORKSHOP · THE MAP FOR STEP 2

Critical and unknown goes first



WORKSHOP · THE SCORECARD FOR STEP 3 · CLICK ALONG

Score nine questions on artifacts

Your Kill Criteria Log decides first. No artifact scores 0

PROBLEM · MAX 6				SOLUTION · MAX 6				TRACTION · MAX 6			
1	Raised unprompted?	0 1 2		4	Used without help?	0 1 2		7	Anyone paid?	0 1 2	
2	Workaround spend?	0 1 2		5	10 times better?	0 1 2		8	Came back alone?	0 1 2	
3	At least weekly?	0 1 2		6	Why now?	0 1 2		9	Growing weekly?	0 1 2	



WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Write the obituary

1 STEP 1 · 20 MIN

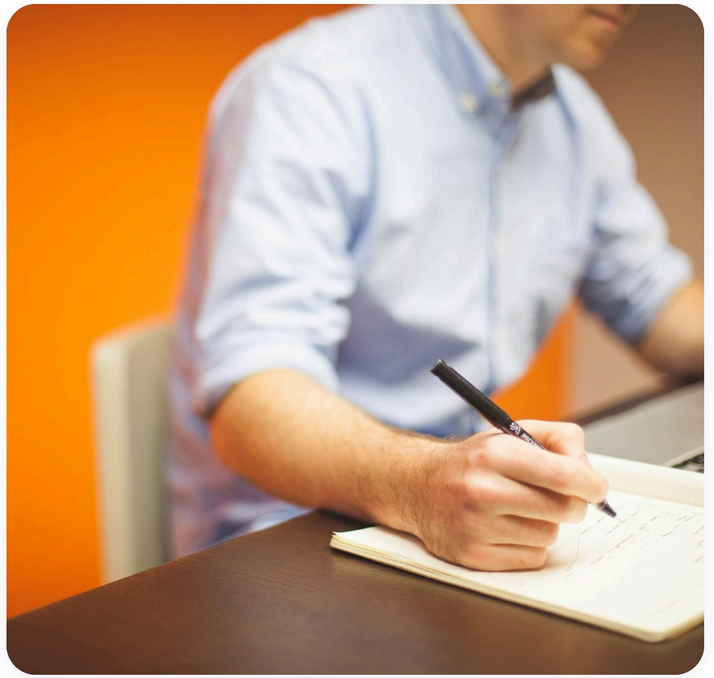
WRITE THE OBITUARY

Find what can still kill your venture

- → One year from now, it's dead. Causes, alone
- → Add the Weekly Reflection's riskiest assumptions since Kickoff (M00)
- → Turn each cause into a customer, solution or business assumption
- → Check each against your records. Ruled out or standing?

Output Standing assumptions, each with its evidence

Minutes 20



20:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Find the monkey

2 STEP 2 · 25 MIN

FIND THE MONKEY

The assumption that kills you if false, and a cheap test

- → Map them on critical and known. Known means an artifact
- → Pick the monkey, the critical unknown, never a pedestal
- → Cheapest test that could prove it wrong. Fake door, by hand, a pre-order
- → Name the people, first buyers and Use Log first

Output The monkey, its test, the people

Minutes 25



25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Decide, then commit

3 STEP 3 · 45 MIN

DECIDE, THEN COMMIT

A verdict on criteria set before, and a week that tests it

- → Read your Kill Criteria Log. A crossed line decides
- → Score the rest, 0 to 2 per question, each with its artifact
- → Get challenged by a team, or by a blind AI read
- → Announce the verdict, provisional. Kill Ritual for what it drops
- → Log the monkey line, commit, send the first asks

Output A provisional verdict, a kill page, a dated line, first asks sent **Minutes** 45



45:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

Score what you have

PROBLEM · MAX 6				SOLUTION · MAX 6				TRACTION · MAX 6			
1	Raised unprompted?	0 1 2		4	Used without help?	**0**		7	Anyone paid?	0 1 2	
2	Workaround spend?	0 1 2		5	10 times better?	0 1 2		8	Came back alone?	**0**	
3	At least weekly?	0 1 2		6	Why now?	0 1 2		9	Growing weekly?	0 1 2	

No MVP or Use Log? Score what you have, 4 and 8 score zero. Your monkey is use without help.

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Test your monkey with 10 people per student from your segment against a line logged first, decide Go, Pivot or Kill on your Kill Criteria Log and scorecard, and bring the verdict and your next offer to the Module 08 check-in.

10 people each

The learning floor is the scored verdict and the offer per team and 5 such people per student.

Your line. Fewer than 3 of the first 10 do what your monkey assumes, and the verdict drops one step.

See you next time!

MODULE 07 · THE KILL DECISION · CASE DISCUSSION · ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Case discussion: 6Wunderkinder

Stand with Christian Reber in Berlin in summer 2012 and decide on Wunderkit, Wunderlist or keeping both.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **List it: every way it could die**
04 **Rank it: the monkey first**
05 **Judge it: your past self decides**
06 **Close it: kill well, then restart**
07 Zoom out: world-size ideas, every quarter
08 Wrap-up and check-out
09 Workshop: kill your darlings
10 **Case discussion**

CASE · 6WUNDERKINDER GMBH, BERLIN, SUMMER 2012 · VOTE 1 OF 2

Focus on Wunderkit, focus on Wunderlist, or keep balancing both?

Hands up for your band. One click on the band per hand



Wunderkit

focus on it



Wunderlist

focus on it



Both

keep balancing

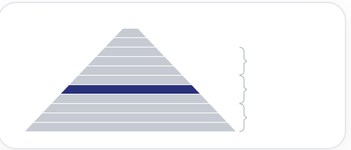
CASE · WHAT HAPPENED UNTIL AUGUST 2012

Two years, two products, one team



6Wunderkinder · Wunderlist · Wunderkit · Atomico · Earlybird

DATA The kill decision (M07) case: 6Wunderkinder, Exhibit 1. Nothing after August 2012.



CASE · THE OBITUARY · 15 MINUTES

It is summer 2013 and Wunderkit is dead. Why?

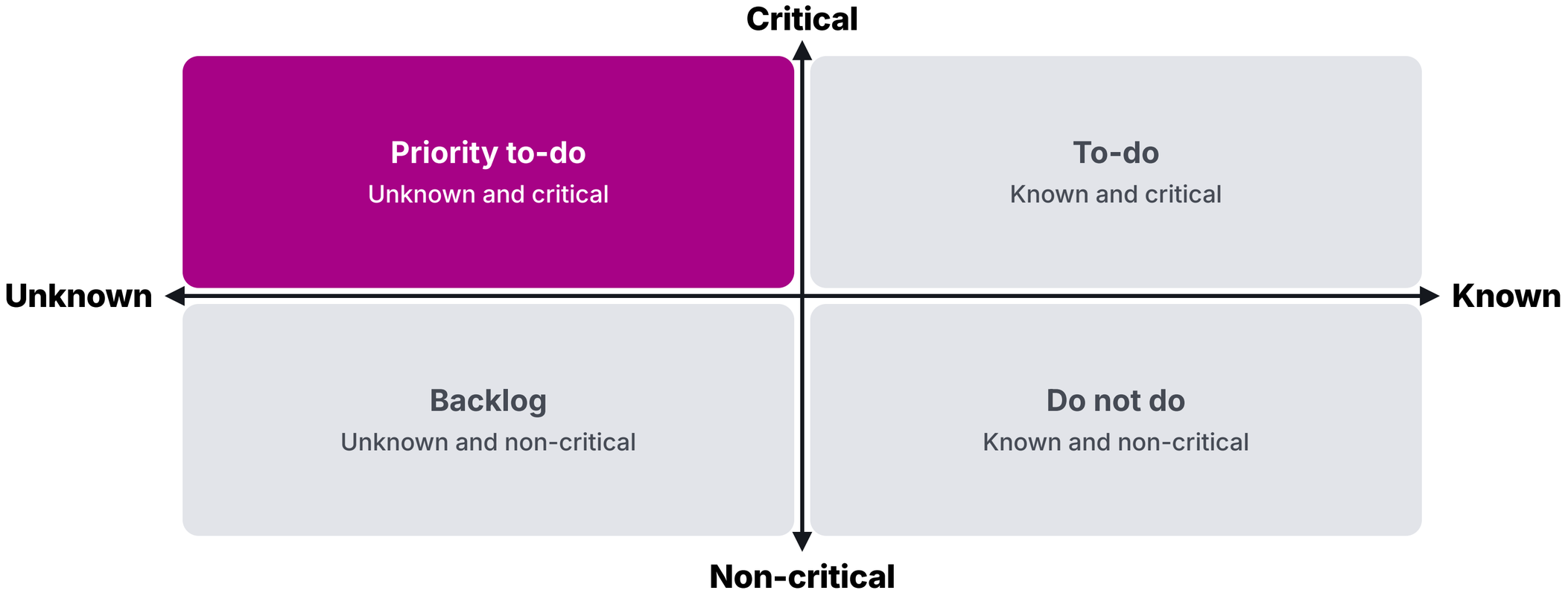
Write each cause as an assumption

Causes of death	Critical and unknown?	Artifacts	Verdict and line
customer, solution, business	the monkey circled	shown, or not disclosed	the line for 1 February

DATA The kill decision (M07) case: 6Wunderkinder. The board plan of the teaching note.

CASE · THE MONKEY · 15 MINUTES

What was critical and still unknown?



CASE · EXHIBIT 3 · 20 MINUTES

What line should have been logged on 1 February?

Then score Wunderkit. Mark "not disclosed" apart from "the evidence says no"



DATA Compiled by the case writer from the company's blog posts and press release and from press reports (M07 case, Exhibit 3, shortened). Dates evenly spaced, not to scale.

CASE · OPTIONS AS VERDICTS · 15 MINUTES

Which verdict is each option?

Focus on Wunderkit	Focus on Wunderlist	Keep balancing both
Go, Pivot or Kill? What would a restart build on?	Go, Pivot or Kill? What would a restart build on?	Go, Pivot or Kill? What would a restart build on?

DATA The kill decision (M07) case: 6Wunderkinder, the closing. Framework 03 for the verdicts.

CASE · VOTE 2 OF 2

Same question. Who moved, and why?

Hands up for your band. One click on the band per hand

Wunderkit

focus on it

Wunderlist

focus on it

Both

keep balancing

DATA The kill decision (M07) case: 6Wunderkinder, "Wunderkit or Wunderlist?". The three options as the case's closing states them.

See you next time!